



Latur students protest against CJP's Dipke

A group of students held a protest in Latur on Friday against Cockroach Janta Party founder Abhijeet Dipke for "abandoning" the NEET exam paper leak fight and moving on to other issues.

P10

October 2: From commemoration to conviction

The birth anniversaries of two great leaders, Mahatma Gandhi and former Prime Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri, are increasingly turning into a ritual of political optics when they should be much more than ceremonial occasions.

P6

Domestic investors cushion FIJ sell-off

After two consecutive months of buying, foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) turned net sellers in September, pulling out Rs 35,860 crore from Indian equities amid global uncertainties, elevated US interest rates and high crude oil prices.

P11

Gayatri Bhardwaj shines in new photoshoot

Actress Gayatri Bhardwaj, who was seen in movies like Tiger Nageswara Rao and Buddy, recently released new pictures from a photoshoot, which has her spotted in a confident and attractive avatar.

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WINDOWS

One accepts Gandhi's principles, another opposes: DKS

BENGALURU: Chief Minister D K Shivakumar on Friday said the country was witnessing a conflict between two schools of thought -- one that accepts Mahatma Gandhi's principles and another that opposes them. He also questioned the move to replace the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA) with the Viksit Bharat Guarantee for Rozgar and Aajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB-GRAM G). Speaking at Gandhi Bhavan here on Gandhi Jayanti, Shivakumar said Gandhi's name and ideals must be preserved even as generations change. "There are two families in this country. One is a family that accepts Gandhian principles, and the other is a family that opposed Gandhian principles and killed him. You are all witnessing the great conflict between these two schools of thought in this country," he said. Shivakumar questioned the need to remove Gandhi's name from the rural employment guarantee programme, saying the people of the country and the world had accepted his principles. The Chief Minister said the world has accepted Gandhian principles and Indians have incorporated them into their lives.

Man stages own kidnapping, seeks Rs 90 lakh ransom

BENGALURU: A 40-year-old man allegedly staged his own kidnapping with the help of two friends to deceive his father and demand Rs 90 lakh as ransom to pay off his debt, police said on Friday. With the help of technical surveillance, police traced Manish to Belur in Hassan district, where he was found staying at a house in the early hours of October 1, they said. Two of his friends, who were allegedly part of the conspiracy, have been arrested in connection with the incident, police said. According to police, Manish left his home in Bengaluru on the night of September 29, telling his parents that he was going to Gadag for some financial transactions. However, when they did not hear from him, they received a WhatsApp call from his phone at around 8:30 am on September 30. The caller allegedly told them that their son had been kidnapped and threatened them, saying he would be released only if they paid Rs 90 lakh as ransom, a senior police officer said.

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Call for CEC's ouster

AAP, student leaders among 700 detained

- **AAP leaders Bharadwaj and Sanjeev Jha, along with some party workers, were detained at Jantar Mantar, while other protesters were detained at different locations when they tried to reach the protest site**
- **Several NSUI activists, including its national president Vinod Jakhar, were also detained from the protest site. Jakhar was detained during a foot march from the organisation's office towards Jantar Mantar**

PURNA SINGH
NEW DELHI

AS Opposition parties and student outfits took to the streets on Friday demanding the resignation of Chief

Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, Delhi Police detained more than 700 protesters from Jantar Mantar and several locations nearby, including former Delhi Chief Minister Atishi. Slogans in-

cluding "Ek kachori, do samosa, Gyanesh tumhara kya bharosa" and "Gali-gali mein shor hai, Modi-Gyanesh vote chor hai" were raised during the protest.

The protesters, including AAP leaders and members of AISA, SFI, NSUI and other student and youth organisations, are demanding Kumar's resignation over the alleged irregularities in the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls and mass deletion of voters.

AAP leaders Saurabh Bharadwaj and Sanjeev Jha, along with some party workers, were detained at Jantar



Police detain former Delhi CM Atishi during the protest against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, in New Delhi, on Friday

Mantar, while other protesters were detained at differ-

ent locations as they tried to reach the protest site.

Atishi and Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Singh were also among those detained. Police stopped Singh at North Avenue while he was on his way to the protest. A police source said around 700 SFI members trying to reach Jantar Mantar at around 11 am were stopped at the Ashoka Road roundabout, with many of them detained. Another police official said around 700 protesters, including AAP leaders and members of AISA, SFI, NSUI and other student organisations, were detained from Jantar Mantar and nearby areas.

Several NSUI activists, in-

cluding its national president Vinod Jakhar, were also detained from the protest site. Jakhar was detained during a foot march from the organisation's office towards Jantar Mantar.

In a post on X, he said several NSUI activists had been taken into custody and alleged that activists were subjected to police action during the march.

"The voice of the people's votes cannot be suppressed by the might of any power," he said, adding that the organisation's "peaceful struggle for democracy" would continue.

CEC must go: Thousands turn up for CJP's protest

- **Dipke dares Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis to send the protesters to jail**
- **The Shiv Sena (UBT) and MNS have extended support to the agitation**

HANS NEWS SERVICE
MUMBAI

Despite police denying permission, thousands of young men and women gathered on Friday for the Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) protest at Shivaji Park here demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar.

While police and security forces were deployed in the central Mumbai area in large numbers and entry routes from the nearby Dadar railway station were barricaded, protesters managed to reach the ground, famous for landmark political rallies.

They were carrying the tricolour and placards with messages such as "Gyanu, Tujha Democracy Var Bharosa Nay Kay?" (Gyanesh, don't you trust democracy), "Gyanesh BRO, JUST RESIGN" and "Gaddaar Gyaanu Must Go". Activists



Veteran actor Naseeruddin Shah meets CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke

from groups such as the Students' Federation of India (SFI) and All India Students' Federation (AISEF) were present, so also were veteran actors Shabana Azmi and Naseeruddin Shah and singer Vishal Dadlani. Activist Tushar Gandhi, Mahatma Gandhi's great-grandson, was also present.

CJP leader Abhijeet Dipke said the Narendra Modi-led central government was so "incompetent" that they had to launch another protest within two months of the Jantar Mantar agitation over the NEET leak issue. He also

dared Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis to send the protesters to jail. The Shiv Sena (UBT) and Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS), which enjoy significant support in the Dadar area, have extended support to the CJP's agitation.

Some residents of the area voiced opposition to the protest taking place in their neighbourhood. Police officials said they were closely monitoring the situation to maintain law and order and ensure that traffic remains unaffected.

Bharat's identity diverse: Bhagwat

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MUMBAI

Bharat's identity comprises diversity in languages, faiths, castes and cultures and it can contribute to building a better world by combining its traditional knowledge with modern progress, RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat said on Friday.

Addressing a gathering at Prabhadevi in the metropolis, Bhagwat also said the younger generation should receive



knowledge about Indian society and its traditions and use knowledge from across the world for the betterment of society. Bhagwat said a person had told him at an inter-faith meeting that religious conflict was causing loss of human lives but a solution to

the problem was not readily available.

"He asked me to come to his country and spread the teachings and knowledge of Bharat to the world," Bhagwat said.

Bhagwat said the eternal knowledge found in the Bhagavad Gita was reflected in various traditions in India and outside the country, though the expressions and words differed according to the time and circumstances.

FDA cancels drug sale licence of Cipla in Pune

HANS NEWS SERVICE
MUMBAI

THE Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration (FDA) on Friday said it has cancelled the drug sale and distribution licences of Cipla Pharma & Life Sciences Ltd's carrying and forwarding (C&F) warehouse at Wadki in Pune following detection of alleged violations.

The FDA said in a statement that the action followed the completion of fresh proceedings in compliance with the Bombay High Court's directions.

It follows an earlier FDA action taken against the facility on August 27 this year over alleged irregularities



involving the packaging, storage, documentation and recall of Reactin Plus Tablets. The FDA had then cited unauthorised claims on the packaging of the Schedule H prescription drug and several deficiencies at the warehouse.

The latest order was passed on October 1 by the Assistant Commissioner

(Drugs), Division 3, FDA Pune, after the department withdrew its earlier proceedings in compliance with the directions of the Bombay high court, the FDA said.

According to the statement, the department issued a revised show-cause notice to the company on September 4.

Special drive for left-out, new voters

HANS NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI

ACCUSED of disenfranchising crores of eligible citizens during the Special Investigative Review (SIR) exercise, the Election Commission has directed its state poll officials to launch a special drive to immediately include 'left-out' and new voters in areas where the poll roll revision is complete. The drive aims to re-enrol eligible voters who were omitted or deleted during the intensive revision, as well as register first-time and 'young voters'. The instructions, conveyed in an official communication, followed a virtual meeting with state CEOs. The Commission emphasised that voter registration is an ongoing process and that no eligible citizen should be disenfranchised because they were not included during the SIR enumeration. Booth Level Officers (BLOs) have been instructed to cross-verify current electoral rolls against pre-SIR lists to identify electors whose names were present previously but dropped from the final roll.

H-1B visa programme should be scrapped: Vance

TEXAS

UNITED States Vice President J D Vance has branded the H-1B visa programme as 'completely broken', indicating he would back its total abolition on the grounds that corporations exploit the framework to substitute American personnel with cheaper international staff.

Sharing his stance via a video on the social media platform X, Vance asserted that the system has been 'totally taken advantage of' across technology firms, accounting practices and various other sectors.

He drew a distinct line between recruiting elite international talent and utilising H-1B permits merely to cut labour expenditures.

"If you're going to bring in an accountant making \$45,000 a year to replace an accountant who is an American making \$60,000 a year, that's not you using



the programme to bring in a genius," Vance said. "That's you destroying American jobs and defrauding the American people," he said.

Furthermore, Vance defended the White House's controversial \$100,000 levy applied to certain H-1B petitions.

This financial requirement originated in September 2025, targeting applicable submissions for personnel located overseas.



Putin: Modi has good ideas to resolve Ukraine conflict

MOSCOW

PRIME Minister Narendra Modi has 'very good ideas' on a mutual settlement of the Ukraine conflict and raises the issue at 'every meeting', Russian President Vladimir Putin has said.

Putin made the remarks at the annual meeting of the Valdai International Discussion Club, according to state-run TASS news agency.

"As for Prime Minister Modi's position on ending wars, I can say that he is one of those world leaders who, despite our very good, even friendly relations, including at the personal level, constantly raises the issue and asks questions about ending the conflict in Ukraine," Putin said.

The Russian leader said Modi 'brings up these matters at every meeting we have and takes a keen interest in them'.

"He has very good ideas aimed at finding mutually acceptable solutions," Putin added.

Ahead of the BRICS summit in New Delhi last month, Putin and Modi held talks, during which the Russian leader briefed Modi on the overall situation regarding the Ukraine war, which began in February 2022, and ongoing peace initiatives.

A few days before that, Kremlin spokesperson Dmitry Peskov said Russia would welcome any peace efforts by India to end the Ukraine conflict, noting that Moscow's strategy aligns closely with New Delhi's position for a resolution through dialogue and diplomacy.

I fought for life, but refused to let others die: Smit tells Modi

DUBAI

FLYDUBAI Captain Smit Machchhar on Friday told Prime Minister Narendra Modi that he was determined not to let others die and managed to save the plane with whatever energy he had left after being attacked by his co-pilot mid-air.

Modi spoke over phone to the pilot, who is currently undergoing treatment at a hospital in the UAE.

Machchhar, who was stabbed and seriously injured by his co-pilot in the cockpit of flydubai flight FZ1073 travelling from Dubai to Tel Aviv on Wednesday, gave the prime minister a detailed account of the incident during the video call and said that whenever in difficulty, he recites the Hanuman Chalisa, a hymn devoted to Lord Hanuman.

"I was fighting for my life but at the same time I knew

I was not going to let others die. It was such a crucial moment. I can imagine with my eyes closed what was happening in the plane. At that moment, I realised that the plane was going down. I had so many injuries. I was beaten but I told myself that I have to get up and act. At that time, I pushed myself to open the cockpit door. The role of other people was equally important," he said.

"After this incident, the

country can proudly say that Indians are not those who take lives, but those who are willing to risk their lives to save others," Modi told the pilot. "At that time, you received so many injuries and were engaged in a fight of life and death. But you ignored your own safety and were concerned about the safety of the passengers. You have enhanced the honour of 140 crore Indians. I feel proud from the bottom of my

After this incident, the country can proudly say that Indians are not those who take lives, but those who are willing to risk their lives to save others: Modi

heart," he said.

Machchhar told the prime minister that whenever he is in difficulty, he recites the 'Hanuman Chalisa'.





Leaders pay homage to Mahatma Gandhi

CHENNAI : Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay, DMK president M K Stalin and AIADMK chief Edappadi K Palaniswami on Friday paid homage to Mahatma Gandhi on his birth anniversary, urging the people to uphold his foundational ideals of non-violence, religious harmony, and truth.

In a post on 'X', CM Vijay stated that Gandhi secured India's freedom using the great weapon of non-violence. Highlighting Gandhi's guiding principles of simplicity, honesty, humanity, equality, and social harmony, Vijay called upon people to fulfill the leader's dreams by building a society rooted in peace and brotherhood, and by protecting the nation's unity and integrity.

Former Chief Minister Stalin underscored the importance of secularism in his Gandhi Jayanti message. Taking to 'X', he urged the public to study Gandhi's life and learn from his teachings. Stalin gave a call to "protect the India that cherishes religious harmony." AIADMK chief Palaniswami commemorated Gandhi as the embodiment of virtue who shook a global empire with the single weapon of non-violence.

He noted in his 'X' post that Gandhi breathed the ideals of equality, simplicity, and truth throughout his life, acting as the voice of the oppressed and the soul of rural India.

Palaniswami pledged to steadfastly follow Gandhi's path of truth and moral virtue. Gandhi was born on October 2, 1869, in Porbandar and was assassinated on January 30, 1948, in Delhi.

Vijay announces Rs 30 lakh reward for Asian Games bronze medallist



CHENNAI : Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Friday announced a Rs 30 lakh cash incentive for sailor Nethra Kumanan, who won a bronze medal in the women's dinghy event at the ongoing Asian Games in Japan.

Vijay conveyed his appreciation and greetings to Kumanan through a social media post, saying her achievement had brought pride to Tamil Nadu and India. He said the Rs 30 lakh incentive was being provided by the Tamil Nadu government to honour her achievement and lauded her talent, hard work and dedication. Vijay also said Kumanan's success would inspire young sportspersons in Tamil Nadu and wished her continued success in the future.

TN dams at 34 pc capacity; drinking water concerns mount

CHENNAI

WATER storage in Tamil Nadu's 90 dams has fallen to about 34 per cent of their combined capacity, raising concerns over irrigation and drinking water supplies as persistent heat leaves 63 reservoirs with less than a quarter of their capacity.

The dams, maintained by the Water Resources Department, can together hold 224 thousand million cubic feet (tmcf) of water. However, their current storage stands at just 76.4 tmcf, highlighting the pressure on water resources across several districts.

Built across different rivers, these reservoirs support agriculture, supply drinking water and meet electricity generation requirements. Many are located in the Western Ghats, where they also serve as important water sources for wildlife and birds. The sharp decline in storage has increased dependence on the forthcoming northeast monsoon.



Water Resources Department and drinking water board officials are awaiting rainfall to replenish reservoirs and help meet demand in the months ahead. Of the 90 dams, 63 are facing severely depleted storage, with water levels below 25 per cent of capacity. Some have little usable water remaining, exposing accumulated mud and silt. Storage in 17 dams is reported to be around 17 per cent. The situation has been compounded by

sediment and waste accumulating in reservoirs that have not been adequately desilted. These deposits reduce effective storage capacity, potentially limiting the amount of water available even when rainfall improves. Although summer has ended, intense heat continues in several districts. The prolonged hot conditions have been attributed to the influence of El Nino, adding to concerns over the depletion of reservoir supplies.

If the current conditions persist without sufficient rainfall, meeting drinking water requirements could become increasingly difficult in several districts. Reduced storage also threatens the availability of water for farms dependent on releases from the dams.

The figures underline the importance of both rainfall and reservoir maintenance in securing water supplies. While the northeast monsoon could bring relief, accumulated silt remains a concern because it restricts the capacity available to capture and retain fresh inflows. Their recovery will depend on how much rain reaches the depleted reservoirs and catchments.

For now, the depleted reservoirs leave water authorities dependent on a substantial improvement in rainfall. The coming monsoon will be crucial to easing shortages and restoring supplies for households, agriculture and other users across the affected districts.

DMK functionary held in multi-crore temple land fraud case

TIRUCHIRAPALLI

A local DMK functionary was arrested in connection with a multi-crore land fraud case involving property belonging to the Sri Ranganathaswamy temple in Srirangam, police said on Friday.

M Ramkumar, the DMK Srirangam area secretary, was intercepted by a special team from the City Crime Branch (CCB) near Panjapur on the Tiruchi-Madurai highway on October 1.

Police sources said he was en route to Madurai to attend a hearing for his anticipatory bail plea. The Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court dismissed the bail petition later in the day, after which Ramkumar was remanded to judicial custody. According to the police, the CCB registered a case on September 13 against Ramkumar and five others, including former Srirangam sub-registrar Vanitha. The First Information Report (FIR) was filed based on a complaint lodged by temple Joint Commissioner S Sivaramkumar.

The accused allegedly used forged documents in 2022 to illegally grab a 7,515 sq ft parcel of temple land, valued at approximately Rs 50 crore. An office for the DMK was reportedly constructed on the disputed site.

Ramkumar and the co-accused face charges under multiple provisions, including cheating, forgery, and criminal conspiracy. Meanwhile, Tamil Nadu HR&CE Minister C Ramesh assured strict action and claimed that the fraudulent misappropriation of the temple's land occurred during the previous regime. "Following



continuous complaints from local Srirangam residents, an inquiry established prima facie evidence, leading the temple administration to lodge a formal police complaint. Consequently, an FIR was registered. The accused's attempt to quash the FIR was withdrawn after the court refused to entertain the plea, and a subsequent anticipatory bail petition was dismissed after three days of judicial review," the minister told reporters.

According to the minister, the accused feigned chest pain following his arrest in an attempt to evade remand. "However, thorough medical examinations confirmed his physical fitness, and he was subsequently remanded to judicial custody," he added.

When asked about the alleged involvement of high-profile people, including a retired judge, the minister maintained that the police investigation is proceeding step-by-step. He affirmed that anyone found complicit in the conspiracy would face severe legal action without exception.

Vijay drives tractor on farm fields, seeks votes in Madurantakam

MADURANTAKAM

TVK President and Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay, known for his penchant for driving vehicles at official events, chose a different vehicle altogether on Friday, a tractor, amid his busy campaigning for the October 6 bypolls. When Vijay's motorcade was going past a village near here, it came to a screeching halt on a roadside location where a farmer was operating a tractor. The chief minister, clad in a white shirt and dhoti, got down from his campaign vehicle and walked straight to the agricultural fields and had a word with the farmer on the tractor, who warmly welcomed him. Moments later, Vijay was behind the steering and drove the tractor on the slushy farm fields for a few minutes and

Ploughing a lonely furrow?



Chief Minister and Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) chief C Joseph Vijay drives a tractor after interacting with local farmers during a campaign roadshow in Chengalpattu district on Friday

eventually brought it out onto the main road where waiting people greeted him for his successful attempt, as driving a tractor was not like driving any other class of vehicle.

The CM thanked the farmer for allowing him to drive his tractor. Patting the ryot on his shoulder, the chief minister posed for a selfie with him. Vijay held a roadshow here across

villages seeking votes for his party candidate Maragatham Kumaravel in the Madurantakam Assembly Constituency. During his campaign, Vijay often hopped out of his vehicle to meet the people waiting for him. He visited differently-abled persons at a village, and walked to a farmland where agricultural labourers were working and briefly interacted with all of them.

He also sipped tea at a nondescript shop with the locals. Interestingly, seeing a woman and her child performing the traditional 'Arathi' to ward off evil eyes, he got down from his vehicle, and he himself performed the same for them and applied tilak to the mother and child duo. Vijay has driven vehicles, including a car, in official events.

Special drive to enroll new, left out voters during SIR



CHENNAI

THE Election Commission will undertake a special drive across Tamil Nadu to enroll new voters and those left out during the SIR campaign, CEO Archana Patnaik has said. The Chief Electoral Officer, who chaired a meeting in this regard with all district officials on Thursday following instructions from the Election Commission of India, said a special drive will be undertaken across all districts for the enrolment of left out and young/first time eligible electors.

"The Election Commission of India, in its communication dated September 29, 2026, has directed that in States/UTs where the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) has already been completed, a special drive shall be undertaken by the Chief Electoral Officer, District Election Officers and EROs for the enrolment of left out and young/first time eligible electors under the process of continuous updation," she said in a release here. Declaration Form attached with Form 6 will be used during the SIR phase only.

For the non-SIR period, the Forms applicable as per the

Stalin lashes out at Vijay for "silence" on SIR row

DHARAPURAM

DMK President M K Stalin on Friday slammed Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay for not speaking up on the SIR-CEC issue and demanded to know if the TVK founder was afraid of the BJP. Addressing a rally here for the October 6 bypoll, Stalin said parties that have extended support to the TVK regime themselves are demanding to know why Vijay has not spoken on the SIR-CEC row. The Left parties that extend outside support to the TVK are critical of

Registration of Electors Rules 1960 will be used, Patnaik said. The Election Commission on February 23 released the final electoral roll for Tamil Nadu in

the Vijay-led regime over several issues.

"What is your fear, CM sir what is the fear? If you cannot open your mouth even on an issue on which all leaders across the country are speaking, what is the reason behind it. CM sir, are you afraid of the BJP so much?" the former chief minister asked. When Vijay was here days ago for campaigning, he uttered the truth, Stalin said and further alleged: "I am happy CM Vijay uttered the truth by admitting that TVK is a branch of BJP".

which 74.07 lakh names of voters were deleted under various categories, leaving the number of electors in the southern state at 5.67 crore.

Investment scheme scam: ED officials arrest two from Erode

CHENNAI

The Directorate of Enforcement, Chennai, has arrested two key operatives in connection with the massive Rs 1,417.86 crore money laundering that defrauded nearly 36,000 investors under the guise of export investments, the agency said. The arrested individuals, S Naveen Kumar and S Muthuselvam, were taken into custody on September 29 under Section 19 of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002, the ED's Chennai Zonal Office-II, said. They were subsequently produced before the Special Court for PMLA cases, which remanded them in judicial custody for 15 days.

The ED's money laundering probe stems from a First Information Report (FIR) originally registered by the District



Crime Branch, Erode, in the state, under money laundering and the Tamil Nadu Protection of Interests of Depositors (TNPID) Act. According to agency officials, the duo, along with their associates, floated fraudulent investment schemes titled "UNI," "FNP," "FAP," and "UNR" under the business names of M/s Unique Exports, East Valley Agro Firms, and other connected entities. Investors were lured with promises of lucrative returns allegedly generated from agricultural export profits.

However, financial analysis revealed that the firms undertook virtually no substantial

export business and were operating purely as a financial trap, a release said on Thursday. Around Rs 1,417.86 crore was mobilised from approximately 35,759 gullible investors across the region. Investigations uncovered that over Rs 719 crore was deposited into various accounts linked to Unique Exports, with investor funds systematically routed and layered through more than 100 bank accounts held by associated firms, family members, and close aides.

Naveen Kumar, the proprietor of Unique Exports and alleged mastermind of the scam, personally controlled the banking operations and fund movements. Investigators found that Rs 390.90 crore was falsely logged as salary payments, despite the firm employing only four staff members.

Jason Sanjay

I am another director stepping into this vast ocean called cinema!

CHENNAI

STATING that he was extremely excited and at the same time, equally anxious about the release of his film 'Sigma', the film's director Jason Sanjay, who is also the son of Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay, has now pointed out that he was another debutant director stepping into "this vast ocean of talent called cinema".

In a statement, Jason Sanjay, who is making his debut as a director with 'Sigma', said, "I am extremely excited about the release of Sigma, and at

the same time, I am equally anxious. The hype and expectations surrounding the film are immense, and I am confident that we will live up to them."

He went on to add, "Sigma is releasing worldwide in theatres on October 2, with Sakthi Film Distributors bringing the film to audiences. We have chosen a genre and a visual colour palette that we believe will connect strongly with the expectations of today's audience. As a team, we have put in everything possible to deliver an engaging and entertaining cinematic experience." The young

director also expressed his gratitude to the film's makers and his team.

"I am immensely thankful to Subaskaran, Chairman, Lyca Productions, for placing his trust in me and giving me the responsibility of directing Sigma. I am equally grateful to Tamil Kumaran, Head of Lyca Productions, who spearheaded our operations and execution. His constant support and encouragement have been invaluable throughout the journey," Jason Sanjay said.

"I am ever grateful to my actors, Sandeep bro and Faria Abdullah, for trusting



me and the script. The film demanded extensive hard work, and both of them

gave themselves completely to the process. I must also acknowledge the valuable

contribution of senior artists such as Sampath, Raju Master and the entire cast who supported the film wholeheartedly," he observed.

"For any director, especially a debutant, having a DOP with a clear visual vision and a strong support system is a blessing. I consider myself fortunate to have worked with Krishnan Vasanth, whose visual understanding has been instrumental in shaping the film. I am equally blessed to have Praveen KL as our editor. His experience and creative understanding have been a tremendous

strength to the project. Thaman needs no introduction. His music and beats are among the chief weapons in our arsenal, adding tremendous energy to the film," he said even as he thanked other members of the unit.

Sanjay Jason went on to point out that cinema was ultimately a medium of entertainment. "As a team, we have left no stone unturned to make Sigma an entertaining and engaging cinematic saga. We have worked with the intention of creating a film that can cut across regional and linguistic barriers and connect

with audiences across territories. I believe confidence in a project must always come with humility. With that confidence and sheer humility, I request audiences to watch Sigma in theatres from October 2 and experience the film with us," he urged audiences. He ended his statement saying, "I am another debutant director stepping into this vast ocean of talent called cinema. At this stage of my journey, the support and acceptance of the audience mean everything to me. Please watch Sigma, support us, and make this journey memorable."

**Private hospitals found selling Rs 86 medicine for Rs 4,528,**

BENGALURU : A shocking revelation regarding the exorbitant pricing of essential medical supplies in Karnataka's private healthcare sector has surfaced during a recent government audit. Inspections conducted by the Food Safety and Drug Administration Department uncovered that critical drugs and equipment used to treat severe illnesses, including cancer, are being sold at markups of up to 5,000 per cent above their landing cost. In one glaring instance highlighted by health authorities, a drug with an original landing cost of ₹86 was sold to a patient for ₹4,528.

Addressing a press conference, Health Minister U T Khader confirmed the massive disparity between the actual cost of procuring these medicines and the final price charged to patients in private hospitals and hospital-affiliated pharmacies. Reports showed extreme variations, with some lifesaving drugs marked up several thousand per cent above their procurement price.

In response to these findings, the state government has urged the Union Government to enact strict legislation requiring all hospitals and pharmacies to publicly display both the landing cost and the maximum retail price (MRP) for each medicine. Since drug price control falls primarily under central jurisdiction, Minister Khader stated that the Karnataka government has written to the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare to intervene and establish pricing regulations to protect patients from excessive medical billing.

TKM records 28,218 units in September

BENGALURU : Toyota Kirloskar Motors sold 28,218 units in September, including 25,027 domestic sales and 3,191 exports. Its January-September 2026 sales reached 2,94,914 units, an 8% year-on-year growth.

11 held for attempt to murder man in two attacks on same day

BENGALURU : Eleven people, including a woman, have been arrested for allegedly attempting to murder a man and assaulting two others in two separate attacks on the same day last month, police said on Friday. The first incident occurred on September 20, when the complainant, Kiran, and his friend were standing at a vacant site on 6th Cross, Maramma Temple Road in Uttarahalli, police said.

According to a police statement, six to seven people arrived on motorcycles and allegedly attacked Kiran and his friend with daggers and other weapons. Kiran was assaulted on his hand, the front and back of his head and his shoulder, allegedly with an intention to murder him, before the attackers fled. A case was registered at Subramanyapura police station on September 21.

Later the same day, Kiran was having food near Arehalli Arch on Uttarahalli Main Road when another group of six to seven people from the Gowdanapalya area allegedly arrived on motorcycles and attacked him with sharp-edged weapons and iron rods, assaulting both his hands, a senior police officer said. When Kiran's nephew intervened, the accused allegedly assaulted him too before fleeing, the officer said. A second case was registered at the same police station. As the probe progressed, police pursued various leads and, acting on information from their sources, arrested 11 people, including a woman, between September 23 and 30, officials said.

During questioning, the accused allegedly admitted to their involvement and told police that the attacks were carried out due to previous enmity, officials said.

Gadag govt school students' innovations selected for INSPIRE awards

HANS NEWS SERVICE
GADAG

Their first innovation, 'Mid-Day Meal Safety Check for School', is designed to help ensure the safety of food served to students. The model uses sensors to detect gases that may be released when food items become spoiled

TWO Class IX students of the PM Shri Government Higher Primary School in SMK Nagar, Gadag, have brought recognition to their school by developing innovative technology models aimed at improving food and road safety. Students Aakash Patil and Daval Saab have developed two separate projects that have been selected for the Union Government's prestigious IN-

SPIRE Awards competition.

Their first innovation, 'Mid-Day Meal Safety Check for School', is designed to help ensure the safety of food served to students. The model uses sensors to detect gases that

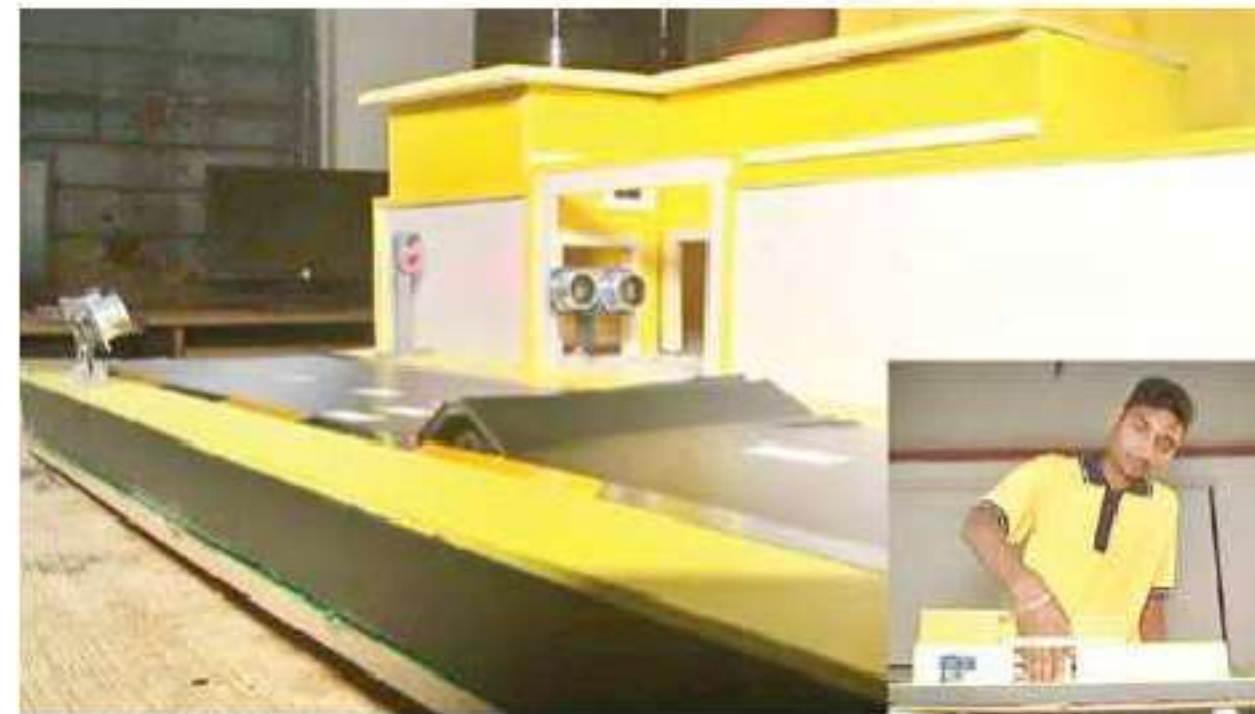
may be released when food items become spoiled. The system is intended to provide an early warning about potentially unsafe food and help prevent students from consuming contaminated meals. The second project,

'School Zone Automatic Speed Breaker', focuses on the safety of children near schools. The model uses sensors to detect the movement of children and pedestrians on the road. When children are detected crossing the road, the system is designed to provide a red signal and activate an automatic speed breaker, forcing approaching vehicles to slow down.

The speed breaker is designed to return to its normal position when no

pedestrian movement is detected. The students' innovations have received appreciation from their teachers, education officials and people in Gadag. Their achievement comes at a time when several government schools are facing declining enrolment as parents increasingly prefer private institutions.

The selection of the two projects for the national-level competition has highlighted the creativity and problem-solving abilities of government-school stu-



dents. Teachers and education enthusiasts have congratulated the students, saying their ideas demon-

strate how young minds can develop practical solutions to problems affecting society.

RSS office printing Form-7, conspiracy to delete votes: Tanveer Sait

HANS NEWS SERVICE
MYSURU

CONGRESS MLA Tanveer Sait has alleged that Form-7 applications seeking deletion of voters' names are being printed at an RSS office and distributed to BJP workers in the Narasimharaja Assembly constituency.

Sait alleged that the forms had reached BJP workers from an RSS office and claimed that a plan was being executed under the direction of the RSS to seek deletion of voters' names. He alleged that Dalits and Muslims were being particularly targeted through objections to their names in the electoral rolls.

According to Sait, around 10,000 applications have so far been submitted in the NR constituency seeking deletion of voters' names. He claimed that several applicants were not residents of the concerned constituency or wards and alleged that 100 to 150 applications had been submitted in some booths.

Sait further alleged that attempts were being made to enrol people from Chikkamagaluru as voters in the constituency while seeking inclusion of names considered favourable to the BJP. He urged the election authorities to examine all applications and verify the eligibility of the voters concerned.

Meanwhile, a police case has been registered in Ballari against BJP BLA-1 Srinivas Motkar and others following a complaint over



applications seeking deletion of voter names. According to the complaint, applications relating to 7,561 voters were submitted for revision, with the Congress alleging that names of minority and Congress-supporting voters were targeted. The case was registered at the Brucepet police station under provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, including Sections 363(2), 61(2), 217 and 3(5), following intervention by Ballari City MLA Bharat Reddy after an alleged delay in registering the complaint.

In Belagavi, the Congress has also lodged a complaint against BJP MLA Abhay Patil over a letter reportedly seeking deletion of 2,598 names from the electoral roll in the Belagavi South constituency. The complaint alleges misuse of Form-7 and submission of false documents, and seeks an investigation. The allegations made by the Congress leaders are subject to verification by the election authorities and police investigation.

CM unveils state's first Gandhi Memorial Pillar in capital

To be established at 87 places across Karnataka associated with Gandhi's visits

HANS NEWS SERVICE
BENGALURU

CHIEF Minister DK Shivakumar on Friday unveiled Karnataka's first 'Gandhi Memorial Pillar' at the Government Arts College (GAS College) campus in Bengaluru. The memorial pillar is part of the Karnataka government's budget announcement to establish such pillars at 87 historic places across the state that were visited by Mahatma Gandhi.

The Information and Public Relations Department is implementing the project under the 'Gandhi Bharat' campaign to mark the centenary of the historic Congress session held in Belagavi in 1924 under the presidency of Mahatma Gandhi.

MLA and Chairman of the Gandhi Bharat Centenary Committee HK Patil, former Chairman of the Karnataka Legislative Council and Chairman of the Karnataka Chitrakala Parishath BL Shankar, Information and Public Relations Department Secretary J. Manjunath, IAS, office-bearers of the Gandhi



Bharat Committee, professors of Government Arts College and a large number of students attended the programme.

On the occasion, renowned Mysuru sculptor Arun Yogi-raj, who created the Gandhi Memorial Pillar, Government Arts College Principal Nagendra Kumar G.C. and Nirmithi Kendra engineer Rajeev were felicitated. Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar also planted a sapling and watered it at the Government Arts College campus to mark the occasion.

A historic moment for Bengaluru
MAHATMA Gandhi, accom-

panied by his wife Kasturba Gandhi, visited Bengaluru for the first time on Saturday, May 8, 1915. During the visit, he went to the then Government High School, now the Government Arts College, and unveiled a portrait of his political mentor Gopal Krishna Gokhale. In memory of the visit, the auditorium at the college has been named after Bapuji. The state's first Gandhi Memorial Pillar has now been established on the same campus.

Details of the memorial pillar
RENOVED Mysuru sculptor Arun Yogi-raj created the artwork for the memorial. The memorial is a 10-foot-tall and 3/4-foot-wide monolithic granite sculpture. According to Information and Public Relations Department Commissioner M.N. Anucheth, the upper portion of the pillar features the national emblem with the four lions, followed by the Ashoka Chakra, a meditating Mahatma Gandhi, the seven social sins preached by Gandhi, his signature and an image of the charkha.

ECI orders re-verification of electoral rolls

Victory for voters across the country: Shivakumar

HANS NEWS SERVICE
BENGALURU

CHIEF Minister DK Shivakumar said the Election Commission of India's direction to electoral authorities in all states to undertake a special campaign to reverify electoral rolls after the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) and include eligible voters whose names were left out was a victory for the voting rights of people across the country. He was speaking to the media near Vidhana Soudha on Friday. "We welcome the order issued by the Election Commission of India overnight following our protest in front of the State Election Commission yesterday. This is not merely a victory for the Congress party or the government. It is a victory for voters of Karnataka and the entire country. It is a victory against the conspiracy to deprive eligible voters of their rights. The Congress has been fighting for the protection of voting rights from the beginning and will continue to do so," he said.

He said the Election Commission had issued directions to the Chief Electoral Officers of all states following the Congress protest on Thursday, including instructions to look into complaints regarding the mass deletion of names from electoral rolls. "The Election Commis-



sion has stated that no vote should be deleted through Form 7. Special camps should be organised to enrol young people who are becoming voters for the first time. Chief Electoral Officers and District Electoral Officers have been directed to ensure this. Detailed instructions have also been issued on the responsibilities of Booth Level Officers and the procedures for Forms 6 and 7," Shivakumar said.

He said booth-level camps should be organised to facilitate the submission of applications. Special camps should also be held for people living in night shelters, labourers and homeless persons, he added.

Shivakumar alleged that BJP workers had submitted applications seeking the deletion of votes belonging to

weaker sections of society. "This is shameful. They are doing this to create a divide among communities, castes and religions. Their intention is to get the votes of Dalits and minorities deleted. Such people are unfit to be in politics," he said.

Asked about the BJP's protest before the Election Commission, Shivakumar said, "The BJP should be ashamed of holding a protest. They themselves have admitted that around 25,000 applications were submitted. This is shameful. They have admitted to the crime and conspiracy they have committed. The Election Commission should immediately register a complaint against the BJP at the national level.

Action should also be taken against those who shared these records, as they have

already admitted to it." He alleged that the BJP could have faced elections by winning the hearts of the people instead of seeking to delete votes. Referring to Mahatma Gandhi, he said, "Mahatma Gandhi once said that if you want to control yourself, use your brain, and if you want to control others, use your heart. They could have won the hearts of the people and faced the elections. Instead, they have resorted to the criminal act of deleting votes."

Shivakumar said that after learning about the alleged irregularities, he had constituted a special team in addition to Congress workers. "A Citizens Forum and activists travelled across the state, collected data and submitted a report. I also verified it through my own sources. I am a grassroots politician," he said.

"I am very happy that the BJP is holding a protest. They are doing a good job. They seem to think that all of us are working with our eyes covered. The media should protect the rights of ordinary people in this country. This issue should be debated on a large scale at the national level," Shivakumar said. This keeps the allegations and political claims as statements made by the Chief Minister, rather than presenting them as independently established facts

43.43 lakh SIR notices delivered; 84,900 Form 7 applications received so far: CEO

BENGALURU

MORE than 43.43 lakh notices have been delivered to electors so far as part of the ongoing SIR of electoral rolls, while the EC has received 84,900 Form 7 applications till October 1, the CEO's office said on Friday.

Of the 84,900 Form 7 applications received between June 16 and October 1, none was filed as an objection to the proposed inclusion of a name, it said.

Karnataka Chief Electoral Officer V Anbukumar on Thursday directed election officials to initiate action against applicants found to have knowingly made false statements or declarations in electoral forms, following allegations of bulk filing of Form 7 applications seeking de-



letion of eligible voters' names.

The development came hours after Chief Minister D K Shivakumar, along with his Cabinet colleagues and MLAs, staged a sit-in outside the CEO's office, demanding an FIR and an inquiry into the alleged misuse of Form 7 during the ongoing Special Intensive Revision.

Form 7 is used to file an objection to

the proposed inclusion of a name in an electoral roll or seek deletion of a name from the existing roll.

As of October 2, the state had 4,49,81,740 electors on the electoral roll, comprising 2.23 crore male, 2.26 crore female and 2,864 transgender electors, the CEO's office said in a statement.

"A total of 43,82,306 notices have been generated across the state. Out of the notices generated, 43,43,137 notices have been delivered, while 39,169 notices are yet to be delivered, resulting in an overall delivery percentage of 99.11 per cent," the CEO's office said.

Of the notices delivered, 35,60,833 hearings, or 81.99 per cent, have been completed, while 7,82,304 are pending, it said.

Entire Kannada film industry to join Mysuru Dasara celebrations

HANS NEWS SERVICE
BENGALURU

WITH the countdown to the grand Mysuru Dasara festivities underway, the entire Kannada film industry is set to participate in this year's celebrations. The Karnataka Film Chamber of Commerce announced the plans at a press conference. Karnataka Film Chamber of Commerce president Jayamala said the entire Kannada film industry, including actors and other artistes, would participate in the Dasara celebrations this year.

"This is the first time such a celebration is being held. The film industry's journey over the years will be show-

This is the first time such a celebration is being held. The film industry's journey over the years will be showcased on LED screens. Two buses will also be arranged, said KFCC president Jayamala

cased on LED screens. Two buses will also be arranged. There will be no film shooting for two days. Rockline Venkatesh has been entrusted with these responsibilities, while the Karnataka Film Chamber of Commerce will make all the arrangements," she said. Jayamala thanked Chief Minister DK Shivakumar on behalf of the entire Kannada film industry for inviting the industry to be part of the Dasara celebrations.

This year marks the 416th

Dasara. An Ambari bus will be arranged for artistes, while seating arrangements will be made for 150 artistes inside the palace to view the celebrations. Arrangements will also be made for artistes to sit in front of the palace, while enhanced security measures will be put in place for their safety. Around 15 lakh people are expected to attend the festivities, with the police maintaining tight security to prevent any untoward incidents.

Veteran film personality

Sa Ra Govindu said the film festival, which had been held for the past 45 years, would not be conducted this year. Instead, the industry had suggested that financial assistance be provided to artistes. He also said there was a desire to have veteran actor Anant Nag inaugurate the Dasara and that discussions would be held in the coming days. Rockline Venkatesh said the film industry had received a special invitation to participate in the Dasara celebrations and that Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar had invited everyone from the industry to attend. "President Jayamala is personally calling and inviting actors, actresses, directors and pro-

ducers. This year, Dasara will be a festive celebration for the film industry as well. The film industry has never received this kind of importance in the past. The government has given greater importance to the film industry," he said.

Responding to the perception that there is no unity in the Kannada film industry, Venkatesh said, "That is not the case. We are all united. Sandalwood stars will come together as part of the Dasara celebrations. Senior and junior artistes from the industry will be present on the same platform." He also thanked the Chief Minister for giving the Kannada film industry an opportunity to be part of



the celebrations. Karnataka Film Chamber of Commerce president Jayamala, Kannada Film Producers Association president M.G. Ramamurthy, Kannada activist and former Karnataka Film Chamber of Commerce president Sa Ra Govindu, senior producer

Rockline Venkatesh, Karnataka Film Chamber of Commerce president B.M. Harish, vice-presidents Sundar Raj and K. Manju, secretary A. Ganesh and veteran actor Doddanna were among those present at the press conference.

Gandhi Jayanti celebrations bring LB Stadium to life



Minister Mohammed Azharuddin, Dy CM Mallu Bhatti, AICC President Mallikarjun Kharge, TPCC President Mahesh Goud and other dignitaries share the stage during Gandhi Jayanti celebrations



Dancers shower rose petals on a statue of Mahatma Gandhi during Gandhi Jayanti celebrations at LB Stadium in Hyderabad on Friday



Dressed in white dhotis, caps, and holding wooden walking sticks, young students recreate Mahatma Gandhi's historic Dandi March during Gandhi Jayanti celebrations



Photos: Adula Krishna



Folk artists dressed in traditional Banjara attire balance brass pots on their heads while performing a cultural dance in front of the Mahatma Gandhi's statue

Congress leaders pay tributes to Gandhi, Shastri

HANS NEWS SERVICE
HYDERABAD

CONGRESS leaders called upon everyone to embrace the ideals of the Father of the Nation, Mahatma Gandhi, and former Prime Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri, and to work towards the nation's development and public welfare.

On the occasion of their birth anniversaries, glowing tributes were paid on Friday at Gandhi Bhavan in Hyderabad under the leadership of PCC chief and MLC Mahesh Kumar Goud.

Floral tributes were offered to the statues of Mahatma Gandhi and Lal Bahadur Shastri. Deputy Chief Minister Bhatti Vikramarka and State Ministers Vivek Venkataswamy and Ponnampalapati Prabhakar participated in the event alongside TPCC vice president Jhansi Rajender Reddy.

On this occasion, the leaders recalled the services rendered to the nation by Gandhi and Shastri. They noted that Mahatma Gandhi inspired the country by leading the freedom movement through the paths of truth, non-violence, and peace. They also highlighted the pivotal role Lal Bahadur



Shastri played in nation-building after independence, describing his honesty, patriotism, and simple lifestyle as exemplary for today's generation. They urged everyone to strive towards realising the ideals of these great leaders while ensuring

that their sacrifices and services are conveyed to future generations. MLAs, MPs, MLCs, state-level women leaders, Congress leaders, public representatives, party workers, and others participated in the event and paid rich tributes.

NHM invites applications for 38 posts in Warangal

HANS NEWS SERVICE

WARANGAL: The National Health Mission (NHM) under the District Medical and Health Office, Warangal, has invited applications to fill 38 contractual and outsourced posts across various departments.

District Medical and Health Officer Dr Rajareddy informed that the vacancies are to be filled on contract and outsourcing basis under NHM for work within the jurisdiction of the Warangal district health administration.

Detailed information on the number of vacancies by post, required qualifications, age limits, remuneration and the application procedure has been uploaded on the official website of the Warangal District Collector.

Eligible candidates are required to submit their applica-



tions in the prescribed format along with self-attested copies of all relevant certificates and a demand draft of Rs 500.

Applications must be delivered in person or by post to the office of the District Medical and Health Officer, Warangal.

The last date for submission of applications is October 9 with the window opening on October 3. Candidates are advised to apply before the deadline to avoid disqualification.

Make constructive use of time in prison: Collector to inmates

HANS NEWS SERVICE

ASIFABAD: Senior officials on Friday visited Janakpuri Jail on the occasion of Gandhi Jayanti and paid tributes to the Mahatma's portrait.

Speaking on the occasion, District Collector Haritha advised the inmates not to dwell on past mistakes but to focus on the future. She urged them to make constructive use of their time in prison and cultivate good conduct, noting that this would enable them to lead a respectable life in society and with their families upon release.

She encouraged the inmates to utilize the various vocational training programs offered in the jail, stating that these skills would prove useful after their release. She mentioned that, un-



like in the past, modern prisons provide inmates with essential amenities—such as proper ventilation, water, light, nutritious food, healthcare, and improved facilities.

She further stated that opportunities are being provided for inmates interested in enhancing their educational qualifications to pursue higher stud-

ies through open schooling, distance education, and open university courses. She urged the prisoners to turn this environment to their advantage and tread the path of righteousness.

District Legal Services Authority Secretary Anusha, Additional SP Chittaranjan, and Jailor Praveen, officials and prisoners attended the event.

Students invited to participate in dist-level drawing competition

HANS NEWS SERVICE
KARIMNAGAR

THE Telangana Art, Physical and Work Education Teachers Association (T-APWETA) has invited school students from the erstwhile Karimnagar district to participate in a district-level drawing competition being organised to mark the Bathukamma festival.

T-APWETA district

They will have to draw a picture on the theme "Saddula Bathukamma - Its significance (then and now)" on an A4-size sheet

president Thaduri Lakshminarayana said students from Class 6 to 10 are eligible to participate in the competition. They have to draw a



picture on the theme "Saddula Bathukamma - Its significance (then and now)"

on an A4-size sheet.

Participants should mention their name, class, address and mobile number on the back or bottom of the drawing and attach a photograph. The entry fee is Rs 20. Entries can be sent by post or courier or submitted in person at the association office.

Prizes will be awarded for the first, second and third positions, along with consolation prizes. Every participant will also receive a certificate of appreciation.

The organisers asked students to send their entries by October 13 to: Telangana Art, Physical and Work Education Teachers Association, H No. 2-7-146, beside the bus stand, lane opposite Kalabharathi, Karimnagar.

For further details, participants can contact 98493 02904 or 79890 74093.



Artisans and buyers inspect finely crafted idols of Goddess Durga lined up along a roadside at Nagole ahead of the upcoming Dasara celebrations. With the festive season around the corner, demand for handcrafted idols has picked up across the city.



Photos: Srinivas Setty



Elaborate security for Amit Shah's Karimnagar visit

HANS NEWS SERVICE
KARIMNAGAR

ELABORATE security arrangements are being made for Union Home Minister Amit Shah's visit to Karimnagar on October 4 to attend the silver jubilee celebrations of Prathima Institute of Medical Sciences. An advance security liaison (ASL) meeting was held under the supervision of Karimnagar Police Commissioner Gautham to review security meas-

ures for the visit. Officials inspected arrangements at the event venues, helipad, meeting venue, parking areas and entry and exit routes.

Commissioner Gautham directed officers and personnel deployed for security duties to work in close coordination and thoroughly review their respective responsibilities in advance to ensure there were no gaps in the arrangements.

During his visit, Amit Shah

is scheduled to attend the silver jubilee celebrations of Prathima Medical College, lay the foundation stone for the Prathima Deemed University building and unveil the silver jubilee commemorative pylon. He is also scheduled to visit a photo exhibition and interact with students.

Senior police officials, representatives of various departments and representatives of Prathima Medical Sciences attended the ASL meeting.

Rayalaseema set for major horticulture push, says Pawan

- Says the govt is focusing on irrigation, roads and infrastructure to help farmers move their produce quickly to markets
- The GHH will connect horticulture clusters with cold storages, pack houses, food processing units, value-addition centres and export infrastructure

PRADEEP VENNELAKANTI
MADANAPALLE

DEPUTY Chief Minister Pawan Kalyan said that Rayalaseema, which has faced drought for years, will be developed as a global horticulture centre rather than being known as a drought-prone region.

Speaking at the foundation stone-laying ceremony for the Rayalaseema Global Horticulture Hub (GHH) and Indian School of Agriculture (ISA) at Madanapalle on Friday, he said the government was working to improve ir-

rigation facilities for farmers and develop roads and other infrastructure to move farm produce quickly to markets.

He said modern cold storages and processing centres would be established to help farmers get better prices and added value for their produce. A complete system covering production, storage, processing, transportation, marketing and exports would be developed to connect Rayalaseema farmers with both domestic and international markets.

Pawan Kalyan said more than Rs 8,000 crore worth of



Deputy CM Pawan Kalyan speaking at the GRR launch event in Madanapalle on Friday

development works had been taken up in Rayalaseema over the past two years under the Palle Panduga programme. Horticulture cultivation had been expanded across 2 lakh acres in the State, including 62,000 acres in Rayalaseema, benefiting around 28,000 farmers.

As part of water conservation, nearly 70,000 farm ponds had been constructed,

bringing another 50,000 acres under cultivation. More than 23,000 road works were taken up with an investment of over Rs 4,500 crore, with more than 5,000 km of roads completed, he said.

Water conservation measures were also being strengthened through Project Jaladhara using employment guarantee funds. These efforts had helped raise groundwater

levels in the region by an average of 3.6 metres, he said.

The changes in horticulture showed the determination of Rayalaseema farmers. KLD apple cultivation had been successfully taken up in Anantapur despite temperatures crossing 45 degrees Celsius. Farmers in the region were also cultivating mango, banana, tomato, pomegranate, lemon, sweet orange, dragon fruit, avocado, apple and berries. Under the GHH, cold storages, pack houses, food processing units, value-addition centres and export infrastructure will be linked with horticulture clusters. The system is expected to help protect 40-45 lakh metric tonnes of produce from losses. From the third year, the project could generate additional gross value addition of around Rs.81,000 crore and create nearly 50 lakh direct and indirect employment opportunities, he said.

AP tops country in SHG bank linkage with key reforms

- SMSE minister Srinivas says state has emerged as the national leader in the SHG bank linkage programme, recording Rs 15,229.40 cr in loan disbursements and an outstanding credit portfolio of Rs 82,639.56 cr

HANS NEW SERVICE
AMARAVATI

ANDHRA Pradesh has emerged as the leading state in the country in the Self-Help Group (SHG) bank linkage programme, driven by a series of innovative reforms introduced under the leadership of Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu, according to Minister for micro, small and medium enterprises, rural poverty alleviation and NRI empowerment relations Kondapalli Srinivas.

In a statement on Friday, the minister cited the latest National Rural Livelihoods Mission (NRLM) data, which shows that as of September 15, 2026, Andhra Pradesh recorded loan disbursements of Rs 15,229.40 crore and an outstanding credit portfolio of Rs 82,639.56 crore, placing it ahead of all states and Union Territories in the country.

Srinivas said the government views loans extended to women's self-help groups not merely as financial assistance



Picture for representational purpose only

but as a means to improve household incomes, create sustainable livelihoods, and strengthen women's economic independence.

Highlighting recent reforms, the minister said digital initiatives have improved transparency and financial security through Aadhaar-based biometric authentication and member identity verification, helping prevent fake memberships and misuse of funds. The introduction of a Unique Registration Number (URN) for every SHG has provided a digital identity that enhances transaction transparency.

The government has also introduced real-time dashboards that enable bank officials to monitor SHG profiles, grading status, and loan details. In rural areas, "Bank Sakshis" are being engaged to create awareness among women about digital financial security.

According to the minister, reduced registration and service charges now save

each SHG up to Rs 32,500 annually. Interest rates, which earlier ranged from 7 per cent to 14.5 per cent, have been standardised and reduced to between 7 per cent and 11.7 per cent, significantly lowering borrowing costs.

The government has also increased the collateral-free loan limit for SHGs from Rs.10 lakh to Rs.20 lakh under DAY-NRLM guidelines while promoting agriculture, livestock development, and micro-enterprises through Annual Credit Livelihood Plans and Micro Credit Plans. Srinivas said Andhra Pradesh achieved over 90 per cent of its SHG credit targets in the last two financial years and expressed confidence that this year's goals would also be met through coordinated efforts by banks, SERP and SHG federations. He reiterated that the government's primary objective is to financially empower women, ensure stable income sources for every family, and accelerate rural economic growth.

PanIIT AP Summit 2026 to spotlight DeepTech, AI, innovation today

HANS NEWS SERVICE
VIJAYAWADA

THE maiden PanIIT Andhra Pradesh Summit 2026, themed 'Andhra's Resilient DeepTech Decade: Swarna Andhra to Viksit Bharat 2047', will be held on Saturday at Dr B R Ambedkar Kala Vedika here.

The summit will bring together thought leaders, policymakers, industry leaders, technology experts, entrepreneurs and innovators to discuss emerging technologies and opportunities for strengthening Andhra Pradesh's technology and innovation ecosystem.

The summit will focus on key sectors including DeepTech, Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning, MedTech, pharma and healthcare, oil and gas, green energy, semiconductors and data centres, Quantum Computing and defence and aerospace.

The event will feature discussions on AI, DeepTech and Quantum Computing, besides deliberations on innovation and investment. Strategic roundtables and



announcements of key initiatives aimed at promoting technology, innovation and investment in Andhra Pradesh are also planned. Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu and IT minister Nara Lokesh are expected to attend the summit.

Prabhat Kumar, chairman of PanIIT Alumni India and principal ADG, NACIN, CBIC; Amitabh Ranjan, vice-chairman, PanIIT Alumni India and registrar, Indian Institute of Public Administration (IIPA) and Sudhakar Gande, chair of PanIIT Andhra Pradesh Summit 2026, corporate leader, entrepreneur and senior banker, will also participate in the event.

BASKETBALL CHAMPIONSHIP

UP, Haryana boys, Karnataka and UP girls reach semi-finals

HANS NEWS SERVICE

THE 51st Sub-Junior National Basketball Championship entered the semi-final stage with intense action in the knockout rounds at the Maris Stella Indoor Stadium in Vijayawada on Friday. The quarter-finals in the boys' and girls' sections produced closely fought contests as teams battled for places in the last four.

The tournament is being conducted by the Andhra Pradesh Basketball Association and NTR District Basketball Association, with the support of the Sports Authority of Andhra Pradesh (SAAP), under the aegis of the Basketball Federation of India (BFI), and will conclude on October 4.

In the boys' quarter-finals, Uttar Pradesh put up a strong performance to defeat Karnataka 65-40. Shabd Kumar led the Uttar Pradesh scoring with 21 points, while Sameer Singh contributed 19. Taksha Jha scored 13 points for Karnataka. Haryana registered a narrow 70-65 victory over Delhi in another exciting quarter-final. Keshav Kaushik top-scored for Haryana with 17 points, followed by Haesh Rathee with 15, Nikhil with 14 and Deb Rathee with 11. Delhi's Jishan Malik scored 17 points, while Vineet, Karthik and Arnab Sharma contributed 11, 10 and 10



Haryana and Delhi players in action during their boys' quarter-final match at the 51st Sub-Junior National Basketball Championship at the Maris Stella Indoor Stadium in Vijayawada

points respectively. In the girls' quarter-finals, Karnataka defeated Kerala 62-49. Aarushi Anand led Karnataka with 17 points, while Dhanya Shree Anand added 12. Kerala's Anna Elsa George was the top scorer of the match with 21 points, while Anyana Aneesh contributed 10.

Uttar Pradesh secured a 68-57 win over Madhya Pradesh to enter the semi-finals. Tejasvi Karhana was the star performer for Uttar Pradesh with 21 points, while Angel Malik scored 15. Monika Dhakad and Eram Khan scored 13 and 11 points respectively for Madhya Pradesh.

Earlier, the pre-quarter-finals set the stage for the intense knockout action. In the boys' section, Madhya Pradesh defeated Kerala 71-51, with Sumit Gujar scoring 16 points,

followed by Anil Khanchi with 14, while Pranjai Sharma and Aksh Choudhary contributed 11 each. Sameer scored 10 points. Harinad P Nair was Kerala's top scorer with 12 points. Chhattisgarh registered a commanding 74-14 victory over Punjab. Shivam Yadav led the scoring with 18 points, while Namo Narayan Malala added 16. In the girls' pre-quarter-finals, West Bengal edged past Odisha 57-51 in a competitive encounter. Ekta Mahato scored 16 points and Bulbuli Hembram 11 for West Bengal, while Iingyasha Jayasree scored 12 for Odisha. Delhi recorded a convincing 75-41 win over Punjab. Chhavi Singh led Delhi's scoring with 22 points and Nyra Khosla added 16. Amreen Dhindsa scored 16 and Samreen Kaur 11 for Punjab.

ED summons Avinash Reddy in Viveka murder money trail

- YSRCP MP asked to appear on Oct 14 over alleged Rs 40 cr deal
- Agency probes alleged Rs 4 cr payment; examines fund movements since 2019

HANS NEWS SERVICE
AMARAVATI

THE Enforcement Directorate (ED) has stepped up its probe into the alleged money trail in the murder of former minister Y S Vivekananda Reddy, issuing summons to YSRCP MP Y S Avinash Reddy to appear for questioning on October 14. The agency is examining allegations of a Rs 40 crore financial deal linked to the murder and a separate alleged payment of Rs 4 crore to the accused who allegedly carried out the killing. The ED is probing the source and movement of the funds and the persons allegedly involved in arranging the money. The summons follows the questioning of four accused persons- Dastagiri, who later turned approver, Erra Gangi Reddy, Sunil Yadav and Uma Shankar Reddy. The ED registered a case under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) in August 2025, based on the CBI FIR and subsequent charge sheets in the murder case.

The agency is examining who allegedly arranged the Rs 40 crore, where the money originated and how it was proposed to be



transferred. It is also investigating the alleged Rs 4 crore advance and the financial transactions of the accused and other persons linked to the case. ED officials are examining bank accounts and fund movements dating back to 2019, covering transactions before and after Vivekananda Reddy's murder.

The ED has also been conducting searches as part of its financial investigation. Searches were carried out at multiple locations in Hyderabad and Kadapa districts, including premises linked to Avinash Reddy, Devireddy Siva Shankar Reddy, Sunil Yadav, Erra Gangi Reddy and Dastagiri. During the searches, officials seized documents and other material relevant to the financial investigation. According to the details of the searches, Rs 24 lakh in unaccounted cash was seized from premises linked to Avinash Reddy, along with keys to two lockers and other documents.

The ED is now examining the seized material and financial records to trace the alleged flow of funds and establish the financial links, if any, among the persons under investigation.

VROs Assn elects new state body unanimously

HANS NEWS SERVICE
VIJAYAWADA

THE Andhra Pradesh Village Revenue Officers (AP VROs) Association has unanimously elected its new state executive committee for the 2026-29 term. The elections were held in a peaceful atmosphere at the Revenue Bhavan in Vijayawada on Friday, with a large number of VROs from various districts participating in the state council meeting. The association is affiliated with the Andhra Pradesh Revenue Services Association (APRSA). The newly-elected office-bearers are Kona Anjaneya Kumar (Chanti) as state president, M Bapuji as general secretary, T Srinivasa Rao as associate president, G Anupama as vice-president, G Dilleswara Rao as publicity secretary and K Sahithi as organising secretary. Later, in the presence of APRSA state president Bopparaju Venkateswarlu, APRSA state general secretary and election officer Chebrolu Krishnamurthy administered the oath to the newly elected office-bearers.

APRSA state president Venkateswarlu said the large



New AP VROs Association office-bearers take oath in the presence of APRSA state president Bopparaju Venkateswarlu at AP Revenue Services Bhavan in Vijayawada on Friday

participation of VROs from all districts reflected their unity. He assured that the APRSA would extend full support to strengthen the VROs Association.

He said VROs played a crucial role at the village level in taking government and revenue services closer to the people. While striving for their rights and welfare, VROs should also discharge their duties with greater responsibility, transparency and commitment, he said.

Venkateswarlu said people expected government services to be delivered transparently and quickly and called upon VROs to work accordingly. At the same time, the government should provide VROs with adequate funds, time and basic

facilities to enable them to deliver better services, he said. AP VROs Association president Anjaneya Kumar said the association would work for employees' rights, welfare and resolution of their problems while also focusing on responsible discharge of duties and effective implementation of government programmes. He said VROs, being directly connected with the public, should provide revenue services in a transparent and timely manner.

"Securing employees' rights is our responsibility, while providing better services to people is our duty," he said. APRSA NTR district president and assistant election officer Batina Ramakrishna and others attended the programme.

Gandhi, Shastri remembered on birth anniversaries

- Governor Abdul Nazeer, CM Naidu and Deputy CM Pawan Kalyan pay tributes to Gandhi and Shastri
- Leaders recall Gandhi's ideals of truth, non-violence, cleanliness and Gram Swaraj.
- Shastri's simplicity, integrity and 'Jai Jawan, Jai Kisan' slogan hailed as enduring inspirations

HANS NEWS SERVICE
AMARAVATI

MAHATMA Gandhi's supreme sacrifice for the nation, his immortal spirit and timeless teachings will always guide us as a nation, said Andhra Pradesh Governor S Abdul Nazeer on Friday.

The Governor paid tribute to the Father of the Nation, Mahatma Gandhi, on his birth anniversary. He noted that Gandhi Jayanthi is celebrated all over the world as the 'International Day of Non-violence.'

The Governor said that Mahatma Gandhi's path of peaceful resistance and mass civil disobedience has been an inspiration for leaders across the world.

"Mahatma lived a life of simple living and adhered to the path of 'Truth' and

'Non-violence' as a way of life. On this day, let us take a pledge to re-dedicate ourselves to the noble principles of Truth & Non-violence by following in the footsteps of the Father of the Nation," Governor Abdul Nazeer said.

The Governor also paid tributes to former Prime Minister Bharat Ratna Lal Bahadur Shastri on his birth anniversary. The Governor said that Shastri's life remains an example of humility, honesty, courage, and unwavering commitment to the nation.

His iconic slogan, 'Jai Jawan, Jai Kisan,' reflected his deep respect for the nation's soldiers and farmers. His ideals of simplicity, integrity, and service continue to guide and inspire future generations, he said.

Chief Minister N. Chan-



Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu pays tributes to Mahatma Gandhi and Lal Bahadur Shastri at his camp office in Undavalli on Friday

drababu Naidu paid tributes to Mahatma Gandhi and Lal Bahadur Shastri on their birth anniversaries. He offered floral tributes at the portraits of the two leaders at his residence.

"Gandhi's ideals such as truth, non-violence, cleanliness, and village self-governance continue to guide us even today. His sacrifices for the country's independence and the way he united and led the people remain eternally memorable. Let each one of us work towards building the clean, self-reliant, poverty-free society that Gandhiji dreamed of.

As part of India's construction, let us walk the path shown by Gandhiji for a developed India and Swarna Andhra," the Chief Minister said.

CM Naidu also paid tributes to Lal Bahadur Shastri, calling him a symbol of simplicity and a shining example of patriotism and integrity.

The slogan "Jai Jawan -- Jai Kisan" that he gave, recognizing the role of soldiers in defending the nation and the role of farmers in ensuring the country's food security, will forever continue to inspire the peo-

ple of the country.

The leadership and dedication to duty shown by Lal Bahadur Shastri, even in difficult times, by prioritizing the interests of the nation, serves as an ideal for all of us. Let us take his aspirations as inspiration and work with dedication for the development of the country, he said.

Deputy Chief Minister Pawan Kalyan said that Mahatma Gandhi's unwavering faith in truth, non-violence and selfless service inspired a nation and continues to inspire generations. His vision of Gram Swaraj reminds us that the strength of Bharat begins at the grassroots.

By strengthening our villages, empowering communities and encouraging self-reliance, we can build a stronger and more prosperous Bharat. Let us carry forward his ideals through our actions, our work and our service to society, he said.

Pawan Kalyan also paid tribute to Lal Bahadur Shastri, saying his simplicity, integrity, humility and unwavering commitment to the nation remain an enduring example of public service.

Rahul’s insinuations against TCS are unfortunate

SENIOR Congress leader Rahul Gandhi sometimes looks irresponsible, if not unhinged. His recent salvo against Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) suggests as much. The country's biggest software company and a major private-sector employer, TCS handles the core digital backend infrastructure and portal management for the Election Commission of India (ECI), known as ECINET. Gandhi has been castigating Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar for quite some time; the criticism is valid because Kumar was seemingly running the constitutional body improperly. There have been myriad media reports exposing Kumar; he has received a lot of flak for his unilateral functioning of the ECI. Recent developments have indeed

vindicated Rahul Gandhi's stand; his party has also gained traction at the expense of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). Instead of giving impetus to the momentum building up against the Narendra Modi government, the principal Opposition leaders seem inclined to take potshots at the corporate world. For years, Rahul Gandhi has ranted against the Adani and Ambani Groups; now, he is expanding the arc of his firing range. This is unfortunate.

This is not to say that the allegations of crony capitalism are without any correspondence with reality; the politics-business nexus is a fact not just in our country but all over the world. But wildly inveighing against this nexus and targeting a few groups doesn't do any good to politics, busi-

ness, or the nation. Responsible politicians and policy makers must examine the phenomenon and strive to formulate a mechanism that curtails, if not eliminates, it. At any rate, Modi did not invent crony capitalism in India; it has always been there, which means that Rahul's party cannot evade its responsibility, notwithstanding its sanctimonious rhetoric against the proximity between politicians and industrialists. What is sauce for the goose is sauce for the gander. Dragging TCS is especially unfortunate, because the Tata Group, which owns TCS, is known for upholding the standards of propriety and probity in the corporate sector—that is, to the extent it can be upheld in India. The Group has built its reputation over more than

a century through a combination of professional management, ethical business practices, philanthropy, and a commitment to nation-building. While no corporate conglomerate is above scrutiny, the Tatas have generally sought to distinguish themselves from businesses whose fortunes are perceived to depend excessively on political patronage.

Their contribution to India's industrialisation, technological advancement, scientific research, education, and social welfare is well documented. TCS has emerged as a global technology powerhouse, earning international recognition for its professionalism, operational efficiency, and ability to compete with the world's top IT companies. Therefore, when a senior Opposi-

tion leader targets a company such as TCS without credible evidence, he risks undermining corporate institutions. Criticism of the government, the ECI, or the relationship between political power and business interests is both legitimate and necessary in a democracy, but it must be grounded in facts, not insinuation or political expediency. Rahul Gandhi has irresponsibly widened the scope of his attacks; this can dilute the credibility of his otherwise valid concerns. A mature Opposition should not confuse between the businesses that warrant scrutiny and the ones that merely perform contractual obligations. Carelessness can vitiate political rhetoric, which in turn can end up damaging the country's institutional and economic interests.

LETTERS

Honour Capt Machchar and the brave passenger

KUDOS to the gallant Indian pilot Capt Smit Machchar, whose decisive, timely action and valour saved the 174 passengers aboard the Israel- Flydubai flight from the jaws of death. He was stabbed by his Oman co-pilot, allegedly with a wilful intention of crashing the plane and killing all the passengers, including several Israelis. One of the passengers also played a pivotal role in helping Machchar. The intrepid passenger pounced upon the assailant and overpowered him. They both deserve the highest honours. Salute to the two who helped avert a potentially catastrophic midair tragedy.

Zubair Khan, Hyderabad

Salute to Capt Machchhar

CAPT Smit Machchhar is most certainly a hero for saving the lives of passengers of flydubai flight FZ1073 from Dubai to Tel Aviv with 174 passengers onboard. An evil attempt to kill the passengers was aborted by Machchhar's presence of mind and valour. It is good to learn that Machchhar is in good health and recovering well.

K R Parvathy, Mysuru

Hail the real-life hero

A big salute to the pilot of Flydubai flight Capt Smith Machchar for his courage, commitment and humanity. It is real incidents like these that inspire generations rather than Hollywood and Bollywood stunts. This brave act shows that one must stand up to unexpected attacks rather than panic, like Capt Machchar, who saved 175 lives. The attempt by the terror-linked Omani co-pilot who stabbed Captain Smith and wished to kill many Israeli passengers who were on board by crash landing the aircraft. Countries which abet terrorists against India must view this incident as an eye-opener.

M Chandrasekhar, Kadapa

Machchhar's composure averted mid-air tragedy

CAPT Smit Machchhar has won widespread admiration for his remarkable bravery during the Flydubai cockpit attack. Even after being stabbed by his Omani co-pilot, the wounded pilot kept his composure, unlocked the cockpit door and enabled cabin crew and passengers to rush in and subdue the attacker. His swift thinking and steadfast resolve under life-threatening assault underline the critical role of professionalism and calm judgment in aviation emergencies. The incident acquired added resonance as it coincided with Mahatma Gandhi's 157th birth anniversary, honouring his enduring message of peace and non-violence that has inspired movements worldwide. Amid continuing global conflict and violence, Machchhar's courageous effort to protect human life stands as a powerful example.

N Sadhasiva Reddy, Bengaluru-560056

Tomorrow is World Animal Day

WORLD Animal Day, observed every October 4, reminds us of our responsibility to protect animals and promote their welfare. The day is associated with St Francis of Assisi, who regarded all living creatures as precious gifts of God. The official World Animal Day theme for 2026 is "See the World Through Their Eyes." It encourages us to look beyond a human-centred view of the world and think about the animals' needs, feelings, habitats, and well-being of animals. It reminds us to consider how our actions affect the animals with whom we share our planet.

Jubel D'Cruz, Mumbai

Recognise Velmurugan's feat

IT is indeed heartening that Velmurugan, a head constable at Kovvilpalayam police station in Coimbatore displayed extraordinary courage and valour by clinging to the roof of an SUV for nearly 40 km, risking his life to prevent gutka smugglers from escaping. The hot chase resulted in the arrest of three persons, who were allegedly transporting the contraband. Chief Minister Vijay reportedly met Velmurugan in Chennai and appreciated him for his daring act. At a time when there is public concern over the effectiveness of policing, particularly against crimes such as murder and sexual violence, the courage, presence of mind and commitment to duty displayed by Velmurugan deserve due recognition. In another incident, 35-year-old woman head constable M Kannagi, reportedly chased a criminal who had attacked a person at Paramakudi Government Hospital and attempted to flee. After pursuing him for about 50 metres, she returned to the hospital, where she collapsed and died. The Tamil Nadu Government has announced compensation of ₹30 lakh to her bereaved family. A police personnel who risks his/her life in the line of duty should not be allowed to remain an unsung hero.

Tharcus S Fernando, Chennai-92

thehansreader@gmail.com

BENGALURU ONLINE

Entire Kannada film industry to join Mysuru Dasara celebrations

BENGALURU: With the countdown to the grand Mysuru Dasara festivities underway, the entire Kannada film industry is set to participate in this year's celebrations. The Karnataka Film Chamber of Commerce announced the plans at a press conference. Karnataka Film Chamber of Commerce president Jayamala said the entire Kannada film industry, including actors and other artists, would participate in the Dasara celebrations this year.

"This is the first time such a celebration is being held. The film industry's journey over the years will be showcased on LED screens. Two buses will also be arranged.

There will be no film shooting for two days. Rockline Venkatesh has been entrusted with these responsibilities, while the Karnataka Film Chamber of Commerce will make all the arrangements," she said. Jayamala thanked Chief Minister DK Shivakumar on behalf of the entire Kannada film industry for inviting the industry to be part of the Dasara celebrations. This year marks the 416th Dasara.

Read more at <https://epaper.thehansindia.com>

October 2: From commemoration to conviction



THE birth anniversaries of two great leaders, Mahatma Gandhi and former Prime Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri, are increasingly turning into a ritual of political optics when they should be much more than ceremonial occasions.

The government declares October 2 a national holiday. Governments and political parties put up photographs, garland statues, organise cleanliness drives and deliver speeches about Gandhi and his philosophy of non-violence. So far, so good. But the larger question is: why should a ceremony become a substitute for values?

Both Gandhi, hailed as the Father of the Nation, and Lal Bahadur Shastri were associated with ethical politics, truth, non-violence, mass mobilisation, social reform, national security, humility and dignity for all sections of society, irrespective of caste or creed, particularly the weaker and backward sections.

Character building begins at the school level. Unfortunately, those who shape the education system — educationists, the bureaucracy and the political executive — appear to have forgotten the importance of teaching the values represented by these two leaders. "Catch them young, and they shall be yours forever" is a popular saying. But the present-day education system seems to have moved away from this philosophy.

GANDHI, SHASTRI AND THE POLITICS OF OPTICS

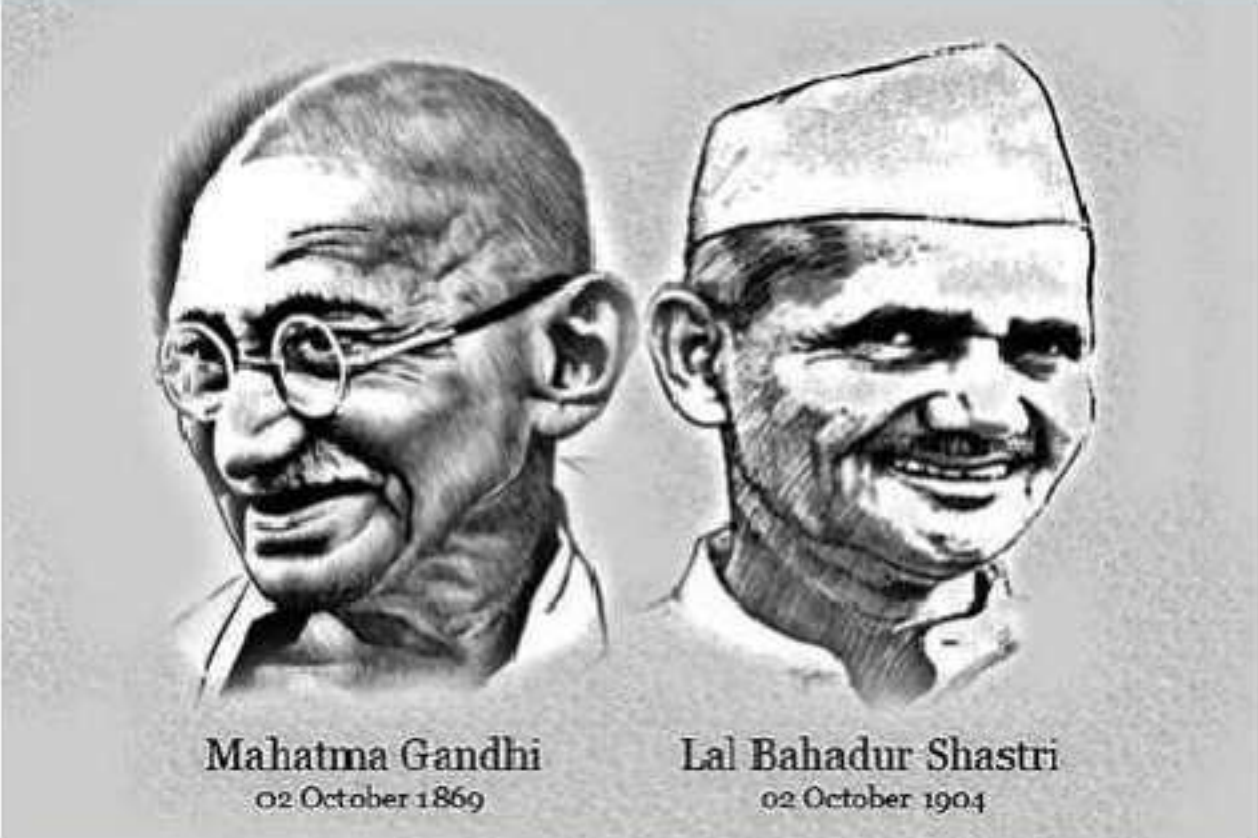
I remember that in the late 1960s and 1970s, Gandhi Jayanti and other such occasions were given much greater importance. As a student of Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Delhi, I had the privilege of participating in debates, discussions, elocution and essay-writing competitions on Mahatma Gandhi and Lal Bahadur Shastri.

One Saturday ahead of October 2 would be devoted to such extracurricular activities. We would spend time in the library, read books to prepare for the competitions in which we were participating, and interact with teachers to discuss the ideas we had gathered and seek their guidance on presenting them effectively.

Such activities are rarely seen today. Political parties speak extensively about skill development while forgetting that skill development without personality development can be a futile exercise.

I would not dare to claim that holding such events in schools would rid the country of violence or incidents of sexual abuse. But it could certainly help some students, perhaps two out of ten or even more, to imbibe ethical values that could influence their conduct throughout life. That, in itself, would be important for the country.

I wonder how many children today know that Gandhi Jayanti has global significance. The United Nations observes October 2 as the International Day of Non-Violence, established by the General Assembly in 2007 to recognise the universal relevance of non-violence, peace, tolerance and understanding.



October 2 should be more than a day of garlands, speeches and political optics. The legacies of Mahatma Gandhi and Lal Bahadur Shastri demand a deeper commitment to truth, simplicity, integrity, tolerance and public service. It is time to move from ceremonial remembrance to genuine conviction.

The legacy of such great leaders cannot be reduced to mere optics — garlanding a statue once a year and then turning the occasion into another platform for political discourse, personal attacks and social polarisation based on religion and caste. Misinformation is another growing problem, with even gods sometimes being dragged into political controversies and described in terms of rich and poor.

Such practices turn commemoration into a superficial celebration.

It is time serious thought is given to ensuring that remembrance does not become a ritual. While Gandhi's message is remembered symbolically but rarely practised, the legacy of Lal Bahadur Shastri is almost

forgotten.

I wonder how many among Gen Z, Gen Alpha and younger generations know about the simple life Shastri led, his integrity, accountability and commitment to public service over power and privilege. Maintaining such standards requires conviction and conduct, not lectures designed merely to earn applause from cheerleaders.

The unfortunate reality is that neither governments, political parties nor educational institutions appear sufficiently interested in promoting the philosophy behind these occasions.

A government can organise programmes once a year to commemorate truth, restraint, institutional integrity and social

harmony. But such programmes should ideally be conducted in coordination with all political parties as genuinely non-political events. After all, virtually every political party claims to respect Gandhi's principles.

The Congress, which itself invokes Gandhi's name frequently, also needs to introspect on how much of his philosophy is reflected in its political conduct. Simply chanting his name does little to promote his teachings.

Political leaders also need to rise above the practice of participating in symbolic cleanliness drives on roads that have already been prepared by municipal workers for the event. In today's political environment, optics travel fast and quickly become material for television debates and social media.

Instead, leaders should focus on improving sanitation systems, changing civic behaviour and strengthening institutions.

When the Swachh Bharat Mission was launched in 2014, the government rightly emphasised that it should not become merely an opportunity for a photo session but should evolve into a mass movement. The idea was significant. However, the response from some opposition-ruled states was less enthusiastic than it could have been, with political considerations and concerns over who would receive the credit becoming part of the debate.

Over the past 12 years, the programme has brought considerable change, but much more remains to be done, and the pace of change in several areas remains slow.

The irony is that political parties frequently invoke Gandhi from public platforms but often fail to reflect tolerance and respect for their opponents. Political convenience appears to take precedence over the principle of truth.

Political opponents can disagree without becoming enemies. Yet the language used against political rivals has deteriorated sharply over the past two decades. Very few appear to practise the principles of genuine satyagraha, simplicity or accountability. Gandhi's principles have increasingly become quotations to be repeated during speeches rather than values to be lived.

The United Nations' message for this October 2 is particularly relevant in this context. It calls for dialogue, diplomacy, empathy, and dignity in an increasingly divided world.

Gandhi should not merely be remembered as a frail man who led marches and fought against British rule. His deeper message was that means matter as much as ends. In present-day politics, however, the end often appears to matter more than the means.

That is why October 2 should prompt a more uncomfortable question than simply asking how successfully the day was celebrated:

What did we change because it was October 2?

Inaugurating a few schemes or launching political agitations under slogans such as "Save Democracy" does not, by itself, constitute a meaningful celebration of October 2.

What the country needs is conviction, not just commemoration.

(The author is former Chief Editor of The Hans India)

Weaponisation of SWIFT and the response of Russia, China and BRICS

BV KUMAR

THE Society for Worldwide Interbank Financial Telecommunications (SWIFT) is a global messaging network that enables secure and efficient international money and securities transfers. Founded in 1973 as a faster and reliable alternative to the telex system, SWIFT now connects more than 11,000 financial institutions worldwide. Beyond banking, SWIFT has been weaponised as a critical tool in enforcing sanctions against Iran and Russia.

The global economy is so tightly interconnected that states can exploit mutual dependence as leverage against one another.

According to Farrell and Newman, this is the capacity for a state to be "so central to an embedded network of interdependence that it can impose its will on others" and the ability to choke and deny resources.

In February 2022, in response to Russia's Invasion of Ukraine, the US, the European Union, the UK and their allies soon imposed sanctions by excluding Russia's largest financial institutions from the SWIFT network. This resulted in effectively preventing Russia's ability to conduct international trade in American dollars and Euros. In February-March 2022, the US, the European Union, and their allies froze more than \$300 billion foreign exchange assets belonging to the Russian Central Bank.

After Nicolas Maduro assumed the presidency of Venezuela, the US policy brought overt pressure followed by sanctions targeting financial institutions and its oil exports resulting in economic strangulation and preventing the country's access to global banking channels and international credit markets. Even though Maduro won the May 2018 Presidential election, he was captured on January 3 of this year by US Special Forces and charged with narco terrorism, cocaine importation and firearm offences. The real reason appears to be the growing share of Venezuelan oil exports to China between 2010 and early 2020 and settling the payments in Yuan or through Chinese banks operating outside

the SWIFT reflecting a gradual shift from transactions in US Dollars in bilateral energy trade. Apart from changing the regime in January 2019, the US and its allies recognized opposition leader Juan Guaido as Venezuela's interim president. The Bank of England froze approximately 31 tonnes of Venezuelan gold valued at \$ two billion, which was its inviolable sovereign asset. The custodial neutrality which has long been recognized in the International Reserve System, was violated.

Confronted with unprecedented economic sanctions following the cutoff from SWIFT and freezing of sovereign reserves, Russia responded with calibrated counter measures. In March 2022, Russia introduced "Ruble-for-Gas" payments in yuan, rupees and dirhams. Consequently, the bilateral trade in local currencies surged with India, China, Turkey and Iran. A year later, Russia introduced SPFS (System for Transfer of Financial Messages), an electronic communication system devised by the Central Bank of Russia as an alternative to SWIFT. The architecture of SPFS was almost identical to SWIFT, ensuring reliable and secure exchange of messages relating to financial transactions. This was Russia's endeavor to fortify its financial infrastructure against external vulnerabilities and enhance its sovereign capability in settling cross border transactions, within Russia and participating foreign entities in 20 countries. 23 foreign banks were connected to the SPFS by the third quarter of 2023. Additionally, 70 foreign financial organisations from 12 countries joined the SPFS as finance hubs, according to Russia's Central Bank Governor, Elvira Nabiullina. Through SPFS, Russia tried to help its financial sector to adapt to unprecedented Western sanctions after cutting off from SWIFT.

Counter measures were also taken by China by introducing CIPS (Cross-Border Interbank Payment System) in 2015, as a strategy to internationalize the Yuan and reduce reliance on SWIFT and the US dollar in global trade and finance. This is not only an alternative messaging system for financial transactions but also to enhance the role of Yuan

in the global financial system, thus challenging the dominance of the US dollar. CIPS aims to provide a secure, standardized, and efficient mechanism for facilitating cross-border yuan transactions and settlements. CIPS supports China's broader goal of promoting yuan for global trade and investment, since it provides a direct platform for international Yuan transactions. CIPS has seen significant growth in both transaction volumes and international participation. By processing around 80 trillion-yuan transactions in a single year and with approximately 1,280 financial institutions from 103 countries and regions connected to the system, CIPS demonstrated the increasing global acceptance of the Yuan. The involvement of several foreign banks as shareholders and participants in CIPS underlines the system's international reach and confidence in its role in global finance. Despite its advancements, CIPS is not entirely independent of the existing global financial communication infrastructure. Yuan's share in global payments and settlements remain relatively small compared to the US dollar, reflecting the challenges in persuading international entities to shift away from SWIFT and the dominant global currency. CIPS represents a significant step in China's long-term strategy to enhance the global standing of the Yuan and reduce its financial system's dependence on Western-centric mechanisms like SWIFT and the US dollar.

While it currently operates alongside SWIFT and within the constraints of a dollar-dominated world, CIPS's continued expansion and the growing international use of the Yuan, signals China's rising influence in global finance.

Under India's 2026 chairmanship, BRICS objectives revolved around "Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability," with economic resilience, development finance, and trade facilitation listed as its core pillars. BRICS is seeking to widen the use of local currencies, strengthen financial and payment infrastructure and expand institutional tools such as the New Development Bank.

BRICS is trying to build a less dollar-dependent

ecosystem for its members. Its official position appears to be an effort to increase the use of local currencies in trade and financial settlements, improve payment interoperability, and reduce exposure to exchange-rate risk. It can imply trade settlement in local currencies, where imports and exports are invoiced and paid without using the dollar. It can mean local-currency financing, where loans, bonds, and infrastructure financing are denominated in domestic currencies. It can refer to institutional and infrastructural changes, such as payment systems, clearing arrangements, and settlement platforms that reduce dependence on dollar-based channels.

A much more ambitious meaning is reserve de-dollarisation, where central banks materially reduce their reliance on the dollar as a reserve asset. The 2025 BRICS Finance Ministers and Central Bank Governors' joint statement welcomed the "Technical Report: BRICS Cross-border Payments System" and noted that it should support efforts to facilitate "fast, low-cost, more accessible, efficient, transparent, and safe cross-border payments" among BRICS countries and other nations. A major analytical error in many discussions of BRICS de-dollarisation is to combine local-currency trade settlement gradually through bilateral or plurilateral arrangements, where trade volumes are large and payment channels are developed efficiently.

Ironically, none of the official BRICS statements suggest that replacing the dollar as the leading reserve is imminent. Instead, they point to a more incremental vision: increasing the share of transactions that can be settled outside the dollar if doing so is commercially and institutionally viable.

Moving forward, states must consider resilience, alignment, diversified interdependence, and possibly deterrent strategies. International order does not hinge on free markets; it hinges on how nations react to weaponized finance or weaponized dependence, such as energy, critical minerals, chips and technological inputs.

(The writer is a former member of CBIC and DG, DRI)

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‘Gandhi’s timeless path of non-violence’

HANS NEWS SERVICE
KURNOOL

MAHATMA Gandhi was a man of peace, who demonstrated how human-kind could be guided by nonviolence, stated renowned writer D Chand Basha. On the occasion of Gandhi’s birth anniversary on Friday, he said that Mahama Gandhi was a great man, who sacrificed his life for the country’s independence. “Gandhi became the father of the nation by following the path of non-violence and achieved independence through peace, truth and religion,” he added. He said that people should get used to the philosophy of living like a common man, expressing values, questioning and fighting. Chand Basha said that Gandhi was a man, who awakened humanity and made freedom and equality the aspiration of the people. He said that Gandhi believed that victory can only be achieved through struggle.



D Chand Basha

Call for unity and peace on Gandhi Jayanti



KURNOOL: District Collector Dr A Siri urged citizens to embrace Mahatma Gandhi’s timeless ideals during Gandhi Jayanti celebrations held at the Collectorate on Friday. Joined by Panyam MLA Gouri Charitha, Vishwabrahman Corporation Chairman Parvathi, DRO Venkata Narayanamma, Montessori & Indus Educational Institutions Head Rajasekhar, and Rambhupal Chowdhury Education Society Chairman Rameshwara Reddy, Dr Siri unveiled a new statue of the Father of the Nation, donated by Rambhupal Chowdhury Education Society.Highlighting Gandhi’s global impact, the Collector emphasised that his principles of truth, non-violence, religious harmony, and cleanliness remain essential for a peaceful, equitable society. She called upon the community to actively implement these values in daily life.Echoing these sentiments, MLA Gouri Charitha described Gandhi as a visionary who guided the world toward peace. She encouraged citizens to make sacrifice, service, and non-violence regular habits, emphasizing individual responsibility toward national integrity.The event concluded with a gathering of prominent officials, educators, and students paying floral tributes to honor Gandhi’s enduring legacy.

Molakavemula PHC gets Swachha Award



MUDIGUBBA: Molakavemula Primary Health Centre (PHC) has received Swachha Andhra – Swachha Award for its outstanding performance in cleanliness and sanitation management.Ministers S Savitha and Satya Kumar Yadav, MLA Palle Sindhura Reddy, Sri Sathya Sai district Collector Shyam Prasad and DM&HO Dr Fairoz Begum presented the award to PHC Medical Officer Dr Nagendra Naik and MPHEO Venugopal Reddy at Sai Aram Kalyana Mandapam in Puttaparthi on Friday.

Tractors distributed to FPOs



PUTTAPARTHI: Ministers Satya Kumar Yadav and S Savitha, district Collector A Shyam Prasad and Puttaparthi MLA Palle Sindhura Reddy stated that the government is working with the goal of transforming agriculture into a celebration by bringing modern agricultural technology and machinery within the reach of farmers. They distributed tractors and other machinery to Farmer Producer Organisations (FPOs) either free of cost or at a subsidized rate.They said that modern machinery will become available to small and marginal farmers at affordable prices through Custom Hiring Centers, which will significantly reduce cultivation costs. Mechanisation offers great relief to farmers who struggle to find farm labor on time, enabling them to complete agricultural tasks punctually. Officials clarified that the selection of machinery, the allocation of rental services, and maintenance procedures are being carried out transparently in accordance with government guidelines. Leaders expressed hope that the use of modern machinery would boost crop productivity and improve the financial status of farmers.DRDA Project Director Narasiah, officials from relevant departments, FPO representatives, and a large number of farmers participated in this event.

‘Swachh’ awards presented to 71 recipients



ANANTAPUR: Anantapur MP Ambica Lakshminarayana, district Collector O Anand and MLC Dalavai Ramadevi presided over the district-level ‘Swachh Andhra Awards - 2026’ ceremony at Hotel Alexander here on Friday. Marking Gandhi Jayanti, MP Lakshminarayana highlighted rural development goals under ‘Viksit Bharat 2047’ and ‘Swarna Andhra 2047’, while noting Anantapur’s top ranking in water conservation and drip irrigation. Collector Anand announced that 71 awards across 22 categories were presented following rigorous third-party field verifications. He also revealed plans for a QR-code-based pilot project to improve garbage collection across mandals. MLC Ramadevi urged citizens to embrace cleanliness as a personal responsibility, emphasising that public cooperation is vital for building a healthy society. The event concluded with dignitaries honoring outstanding local organisations, schools, and individuals for their sanitation efforts.

Gandhi, Shastri’s ideals continue to inspire generations: Farooq

HANS NEWS SERVICE
NANDYAL/KURNOOL

LAW and Minority Welfare Minister NMD Farooq and district Collector G Raja Kumari commemorated the birth anniversaries of Mahatma Gandhi and former Prime Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri in Nandyal on Friday.

Paying floral tributes at Gandhi Chowk, Minister Farooq highlighted Gandhi’s enduring legacy of truth, peace, and non-violence, while also urging farmers to adopt scientific practices to promote Rayalaseema products like Banganapalli mangoes internationally. Recalling Gandhi’s contribution to the freedom struggle, he said Mahatma’s principles and peaceful approach remained relevant even today. He also expressed concern over the



Minister NMD Farooq along with district Collector G Raja Kumari paying floral tributes to the statue of Mahatma Gandhi in Nandyal on Friday

rising temperatures, observing that the weather was unusually hot this year compared to previous years. He said Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu was according special attention to the development of Rayalaseema, particularly horticulture sector.

Collector Raja Kumari praised Gandhi’s peaceful freedom movements and

honored Shastri’s leadership, emphasising his iconic slogan, ‘Jai Jawan, Jai Kisan’, which celebrates the vital roles of soldiers and farmers. Through movements such as the Quit India Movement, Non-Cooperation Movement and Civil Disobedience Movement, Gandhi mobilised people against British rule and strengthened the

peaceful struggle for independence.

Meanwhile in Kurnool, district Collector Dr A Siri and Panyam MLA Gowru Charitha Reddy paid floral tributes to Mahatma Gandhi at the Collectorate.

Dr. Siri stressed the importance of upholding communal harmony, environmental protection, and cleanliness, urging youth to balance their rights with civic responsibilities. MLA Charitha Reddy echoed these sentiments, noting how initiatives like Swachh Bharat reflect the Mahatma’s vision for a clean and united nation.

Across both districts, leaders emphasised that the timeless values of these national icons remain crucial for guiding future generations toward social justice, peace, and national progress.

Rajpath Infra honours Puttaparthi MLA



Rajpath Infra representatives presenting the Guinness World Record shield to MLA Palle Sindhura Reddy and former Minister Dr Palle Raghunatha Reddy in Puttaparthi on Friday

HANS NEWS SERVICE
PUTTAPARTHI

REPRESENTATIVES from Rajpath Infra on Friday met Puttaparthi MLA Palle Sindhura Reddy and former Minister Dr Palle Raghunatha Reddy and expressed gratitude for their cooperation during the construction of NH-544G Bengaluru-Vijayawada Greenfield Highway near Sadarlapalli.

The company made history by setting a Guinness World Record, completing 28.95 lane-kilometers of bituminous concrete work and utilizing 10,675 metric tonnes of material within just 24 hours.

During the meeting, representatives Jagadish Kadam and Mohana Jagadish Kadam presented the Guinness World Record shield to the leaders.

Praising the achievement, MLA Sindhura Reddy stated that the record is a matter of immense pride for the Satya Sai district. She congratulated the engineers, management, and workers for using advanced technology to accomplish the massive infrastructure feat. She added that the new highway will drastically enhance regional transport, spurring industrial, commercial, and tourism growth across the constituency.

MLA assures to resolve public grievances

HANS NEWS SERVICE
PUTTAPARTHI

PUTTAPARTHI MLA Palle Sindhura Reddy and former Minister Dr Palle Raghunatha Reddy stated that public grievance programmes are being conducted in Puttaparthi constituency with the aim of directly understanding people’s issues and providing solutions.

During public grievance programme held here on Friday, MLA Sindhura Reddy and former Minister Dr Palle Raghunatha Reddy received petitions from the public from various parts of the constituency.The MLA stated that every petition submitted by the public would be examined and measures would be taken to resolve them after consulting officials concerned. She assured that efforts would be made to ensure that every eligible person receives the benefits of government welfare schemes.

Most of the public representations include revenue issues, pensions, drinking water supply, housing, and electricity. Earlier, the MLA planted saplings at Puttaparthi MLA camp office. She called upon everyone to contribute to environmental protection and urged individuals to plant saplings to enhance greenery.



Prisons must focus on reform: Collector

HANS NEWS SERVICE
ANANTAPUR

DISTRICT Collector O Anand emphasised the importance of inmate reform and social reintegration while serving as chief guest at the ‘Prisoners’ Day’ event held at Anantapur District Central Jail on Friday to mark Mahatma Gandhi’s 157th birth anniversary.

Highlighting Andhra Pradesh’s pioneering welfare programs for prisoners, the Collector urged inmates to maintain good conduct, participate actively in vocational livelihood activities, and prepare to lead independent lives upon release. He assured full government backing, including support for establishing



small-scale industries and access to free legal aid through the District Legal Services Authority. Drawing inspiration from Mahatma Gandhi’s time spent reading in jail, he encouraged inmates to utilize the prison library to transform into upstanding citizens. District Legal Services Authority Secretary Rajasekhar also addressed

the gathering, detailing available free legal assistance. The event began with dignitaries paying floral tributes to Mahatma Gandhi’s portrait.

Additional SP Iliyas Basha, Jail Superintendent Venugopal Reddy, and various officials attended, celebrating a shared vision of rehabilitation and fresh beginnings for the inmates.

95 bonded labourers rescued from charcoal units

HANS NEWS SERVICE
ANANTAPUR

A coordinated special drive by the District Vigilance Committee successfully rescued 95 bonded labourers, including numerous children, from charcoal-burning units in Bommanahal and D Hirehal mandals on September 30.

Acting on instructions from the district Collector, multi-departmental teams alongside NGO representatives intercepted the workers—belonging to Maharashtra’s Adivasi communities—who were trapped due to employer advances



and harassment.

The Sub-Divisional Magistrate issued official Release Certificates at the Rayadurg Tahsildar’s Office, and arrangements were made to transport the victims safely back to Raigad via APSRTC buses. Authorities have initiated criminal cases against the employers under the

Bonded Labour System (Abolition) Act.

Each released individual is eligible for immediate financial assistance of up to forty thousand rupees and comprehensive rehabilitation support, including education for children and healthcare, under central schemes.

Tirupati Archer Ganesh wins gold, bronze at Asian Games

TIRUPATI

HINDUSTAN Coca-Cola Beverages (HCCB), which supported Tirupati-based archer Ganesh Mani Ratnam Thirumuru with precision archery equipment ahead of 20th Asian Games (Aichi-Nagoya 2026), celebrated his achievement of winning gold in Men’s Compound Team Event and Bronze in Men’s Individual Compound Event.

Avinash Kant Kumar, Head of Integrated Supply Chain, Hindustan Coca-Cola Beverages (HCCB), said that they were delighted to see Ganesh Mani Ratnam Thirumuru bring laurels to India and make the state proud through his outstanding performance at the 20th Asian Games (Aichi-Nagoya 2026). HCCB is proud to have supported



Ganesh Mani Ratnam with his medals at the Asian Games

ported Ganesh with precision archery equipment and to celebrate this remarkable achievement. Sports Authority of Andhra Pradesh (SAAP) Chairman A Ravi Naidu also hailed the victory of Ganesh in the Asian Games. He said that it was a proud movement for the state that Ganesh has defeated a China player to win his bronze medal in the individual category.

Pottepalem bridge inaugurated

HANS NEWS SERVICE
NELLORE

A major relief to the people of Pottepalem and surrounding villages from a 50-year-old problem as the Bridge cum Causeway was inaugurated by Nellore Rural MLA Kotamreddy Sridhar Reddy, along with district Collector Himanshu Shukla at Pottepalem village of Nellore rural mandal on Friday.

People of these areas used to face problems to cross the road during rainy season due to lack of bridge. During 2024 electioneering, Kotamreddy Sridhar Reddy assured the people that he would redress this major problem if people vote for TDP in the elections.

After getting elected as MLA, Kotamreddy took steps for the construction of



Rural MLA Kotamreddy Sridhar Reddy along with district Collector Himanshu Shukla inaugurating the Bridge cum Causeway at Pottepalem village on Friday

a bridge across Kaluju (water channel) at Pottepalem village at a cost of Rs 6.54 crore. Speaking on the occasion, MLA Kotamreddy said the bridge would provide a permanent solution to a problem that had persisted for nearly 50 years. He assured that he would continue to fight for resolving the problems faced by people in

Nellore Rural constituency. The MLA thanked Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu, Deputy CM Pawan Kalyan, Minister Nara Lokesh, Ministers P Narayana and Anam Ramanarayana Reddy, MP Vemireddy Prabhakar Reddy and other leaders for extending support to achieve such mammoth task.

Man arrested in theft case

TIRUPATI: Tirupati Rural police on Friday arrested a 50-year-old man in connection with a theft case and recovered 60 grams of gold jewellery worth Rs 9 lakh.

The accused was identified as Govindaswamy, a resident of Chennai. He is an auto driver and originally belongs to Shankarapuram village in Gudiyatham of Vellore district. According to police, the accused visited Tirumala on September 21 and later came to Tirupati to steal valuables. He allegedly stole a mobile phone from a person at a dental hospital in Bairagipateta by using a paper sheet as a cover. Later, he reportedly stole a packet containing gold jewellery from a table at Andhra Pradesh Grameena Bank branch in Dhanalakshmi Nagar when the person at the counter moved away.

Fetes sanitation workers for their services



Minister Satya Kumar Yadav administering oath to people in Dharmavaram on Friday

HANS NEWS SERVICE
DHARMAVARAM

HEALTH Minister and Dharmavaram MLA Satya Kumar Yadav urged citizens to embrace cleanliness as a core social responsibility to transform Dharmavaram into a clean and healthy city, true to Mahatma Gandhi’s ideals. Commemorating Gandhi Jayanti on Friday, he participated in cleaning operations alongside municipal sanitation workers during the ‘Swachhata Hi Seva 2026’ program held at the busy local vegetable market.

Paying rich tributes to the Father of the Nation, Minister Yadav recalled Gandhi’s historic contributions to India’s independence and his emphasis on hygiene, environmental sanitation, and rural development.

He stressed that clean surroundings serve as the foundation of a healthy society and that practicing cleanliness is a fitting tribute to Gandhiji.

Highlighting nationwide efforts under the Swachh Bharat campaign, he noted that while municipalities handle routine sanitation, complete urban cleanliness requires active public participation.

He called on every family to keep both their homes and immediate surroundings spotless.

During the event, the Minister joined sanitation workers in clearing garbage and debris, setting an example for the community.

Afterward, he specially commended their dedication, noting they toil daily in all weather conditions to protect public health, and felicitated them with garlands and shawls.

Urging residents to act responsibly, Minister Yadav advised against indiscriminate littering, encouraging proper waste segregation into wet and dry categories, and prompt reporting of neighborhood sanitation issues.

Finally, he called upon youth, voluntary organisations, and political activists to unite behind the ‘Clean Dharmavaram’ initiative, emphasising that a truly clean town can only be achieved through collective community effort.

Dharmavaram RDO Rambhupal Reddy, Municipal Commissioner Venkataramanayya, local BJP leaders, municipal staff, sanitation workers, and others participated in the event.



Why early genetic testing matters for children with developmental delays

DR. PRIYA YADAV

Developmental delays are among the most common concerns in paediatrics and paediatric neurology practice, affecting 1–3 per cent of children worldwide. In India, studies suggest that nearly 10–15 per cent of school-aged children experience cognitive or learning difficulties, while 1 in 8 children under the age of two years show signs of developmental delay. For families, the uncertainty surrounding the cause of these delays can be deeply distressing. Early genetic testing, combined with structured genetic counselling, offers a pathway to clarity, timely intervention, and informed family planning.

Genetic Testing: Unlocking the diagnostic puzzle
Genetic testing has revolutionized the evaluation of children with unexplained developmental

delays. Research indicates that 30–40% of such cases have a genetic component or risk predisposition, and with advanced technologies like chromosomal microarray (CMA) and whole exome sequencing (WES), diagnostic yields can reach up to 50%. Genetic Testing & Counselling is very important for families with children suffering from Development Delays, Intellectual Disability, Cognitive Impairment, Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder, Autism & Autism Spectrum Disorders in various ways such as:

Precision medicine: Identifying a genetic etiology allows clinicians to tailor interventions. For example, metabolic disorders such as phenylketonuria or biotinidase deficiency can be treated effectively if diagnosed early.
Reducing the diagnostic odyssey: Families often undergo years of inconclusive investigations. Genetic testing provides clarity, reducing unnecessary procedures and costs.
Family implications: Many genetic conditions are inherited. Testing helps identify recurrence risks, guides re-



productive choices, and enables carrier testing in parents and siblings.

In India, the rare disease burden is also significant, with an estimated 70 million individuals affected, many presenting as developmental delays in childhood. Consanguinity in certain regions further increases the

Early genetic testing can help identify the causes of unexplained developmental delays in children, enabling timely treatment and intervention. Combined with genetic counselling, it also helps families understand diagnoses, manage risks and make informed decisions about their child's future

prevalence of autosomal recessive disorders. Despite this, a 2024 survey revealed that the average time to diagnosis for rare genetic conditions in

India is 5–7 years, highlighting the urgent need for early genetics awareness programs, enhanced genetic outreach OPDs, coupled with genetic testing.

Genetic Counselling: The human bridge between genomic science and families

While genetic testing provides answers, genetic counselling ensures those answers are understood, contextualized, and acted upon. Genetic Counselling is not merely an adjunct; it is central to the process for:

Explaining the test: Families are guided through the purpose, scope, and limitations of genetic tests, including the possibility of variants of uncertain significance (VUS).

Interpreting results: Genetic Counsellors help families understand whether findings are pathogenic, benign, or uncertain, and what this mean for the child's health and prognosis, including the risk explanation to future pregnancies.

Psychological support: The uncertainty of genetic results can cause anxiety. Genetic Counselling provides reassurance, emphasizes ongoing monitoring, and offers coping strategies.

Family screening and prevention: Counselling highlights the importance of testing siblings or parents, and preventive surveillance such as cardiac monitoring in connective tissue disorders.

Reproductive guidance:



Families are empowered to make informed choices, including prenatal testing and pre-implantation genetic diagnosis (PGD), reducing recurrence risks in future pregnancies.

In India, where awareness of genetic counselling remains limited, integrating counselling into paediatric care is vital. It ensures that families are not left alone with complex genetic information but are supported in making decisions that affect both present and future generations.

What should change in routine clinical practice?

Early referral: Any child with unexplained developmental delay, intellectual disability, or multiple congenital anomalies should be referred for genetic evaluation.

Tiered testing approach: Begin with CMA for copy

number variations, followed by WES or targeted panels for single-gene disorders.

Multidisciplinary care: Collaboration between paediatricians, neurologists, geneticists, and counsellors ensures holistic management.

Policy integration: India must strengthen neonatal screening and early childhood intervention programs to include genetic testing and counselling.

"In the fight against unexplained developmental delays, genetic testing and counselling are not luxuries; they are lifelines. Every child deserves the chance for an early diagnosis, every family deserves clarity, and every society must recognise that investing in genetics today secures healthier generations tomorrow."

(The writer is a Head - CSVG, Metropolis Healthcare Ltd.)

Jasmine Sandlas reveals why she wants to be remembered as 'the girl who sang about love'



Singer Jasmine Sandlas has opened up about the kind of musical legacy she hopes to leave behind.

In her recent post on Instagram, the 'Dhurandhar' singer said she wants her songs to be associated with love even years after she is gone. Sharing her thoughts on love and music, Jasmine said she hopes to create a large body of songs centred around the emotion and be remembered for expressing it

through her music.

"I wanna sing 100 songs about Love and in 100 years if anyone even remembers me, I want to be known as the girl who sang about love," she said. The 'Bamb Jatt' hit-maker also posted her photos in a white dress. She is seen striking different and candid poses for the camera.

Previously, Jasmine had shared a glimpse of one of her favourite moments from her ongoing "The Dream Girl

Tour," describing the experience as "unreal and ethereal." She shared a video from her concert in Bengaluru and said it was among the moments from the tour that she holds particularly close to her heart. "This moment was unreal and ethereal.

This is one of my top favourite moments from 'The Dream Girl Tour.' It was in Bangalore," she wrote. Jasmine also revealed that she prefers receiving videos

recorded by fans from within the audience rather than professionally curated concert footage. She said these recordings allow her to hear the audience singing along and feel their emotions more closely.

Work-wise, Jasmine Sandlas recently collaborated with Satinder Sartaaj on the romantic track "Jaiye Sajana" from the film "Dhurandhar: The Revenge."

The singer is widely

recognized for her distinctive voice and a string of popular tracks that have become an important part of her musical journey. Her songs, such as "Yaar Naa Miley" from Kick, "Illegal Weapon 2.0" with Garry Sandhu, "Patt Lai Geya", and collaborations including "Bamb Jatt" and "Mithi Mithi" with Amrit Maan, have earned her a strong following among Punjabi and Bollywood music listeners.

Smriti Irani says Tulsi Virani's story 'quietly expanded' what women believed was possible

Actress-politician Smriti Irani has looked back on the impact of her iconic television character Tulsi Virani from the iconic show "Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi", marking 25 years since the character first entered Indian living rooms.

She went on to credit producer Ekta Kapoor with putting women at the heart of prime-time television and changing the way stories were told on the small screen.

Smriti took to Instagram, where she re-shared video highlighting research titled "The Power of TV: Cable Television and Women's Status in India", conducted by economists at Harvard University. The video explored how Ekta Kapoor's television shows positively influenced women's lives in rural India, including attitudes towards women's autonomy and domestic violence.

Turning to the caption section, Smriti wrote: "Twenty-five years ago, Tulsi Virani walked into India's living rooms. Neither of us knew how far she would travel. Behind her was another young woman breaking the mould — Ekta Kapoor, a young producer who trusted her instinct, put women at the heart of prime-time television and changed the grammar of Indian entertainment."

Smriti then wrote about the "academic research of



cable television in rural India."

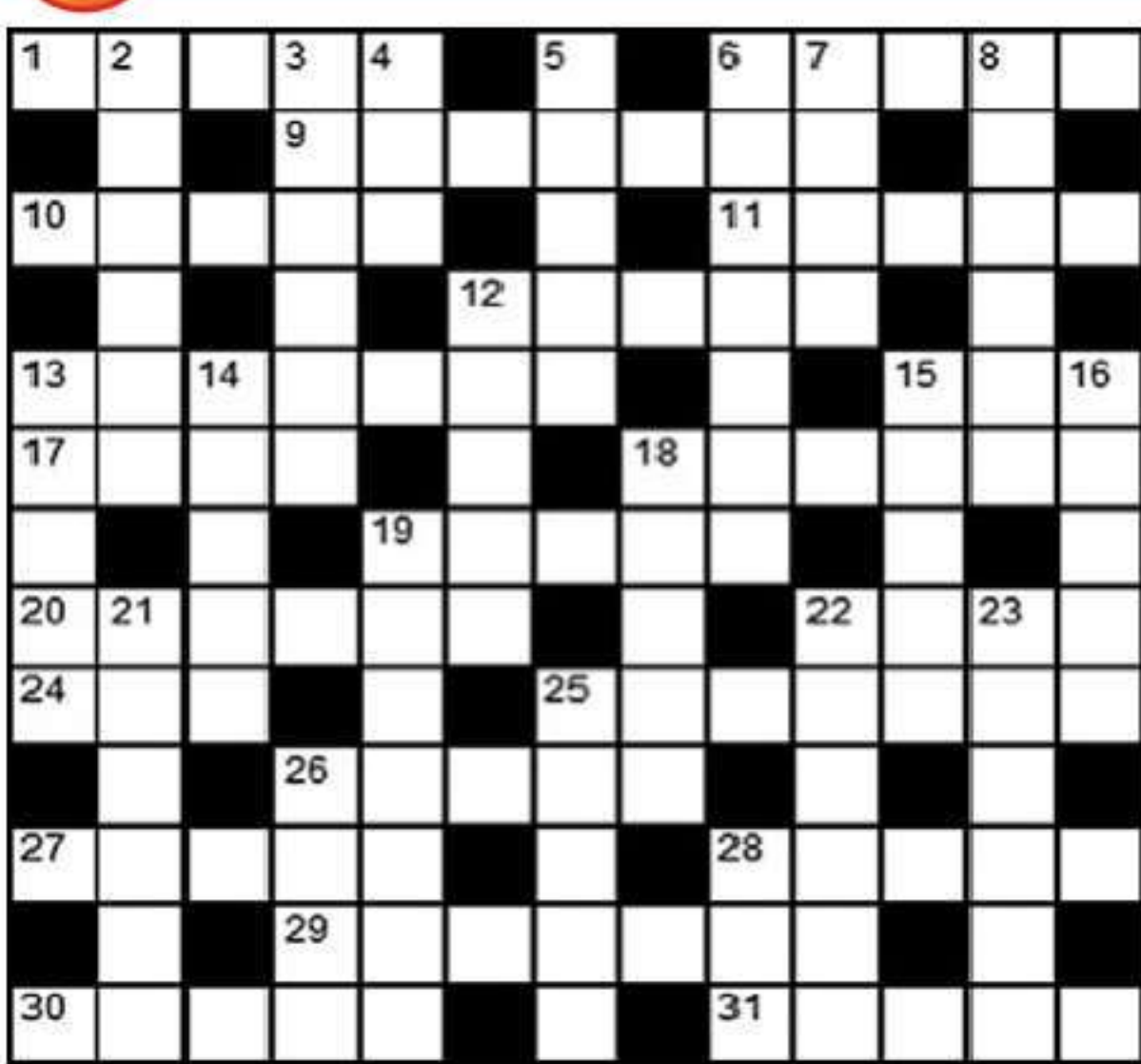
"Years later, academic research on the spread of cable television in rural India found that exposure to television was associated with changing attitudes towards women — including autonomy, education and domestic violence."

"It reinforced something I have always believed: Stories don't just reflect society. Sometimes, they quietly expand what society believes is possible. A

character can question a boundary before someone finds the courage to question it in her own life. A young girl watching can discover a possibility she had never imagined for herself."

She concluded: "Today, many of the young women who watched Tulsi are raising daughters of their own. Perhaps that is the true measure of a story. The episode ends. The years pass. A generation grows up. But somewhere, the story continues."

CROSSWORD



ACROSS

- Inventory (5)
- Yellow fever bug (5)
- Insinuating (7)
- Cause to lose courage (5)
- Concur (5)
- Borders on (5)
- Mouths of volcanos (7)
- Suffix with "comp" or "exec" (3)
- Rowing blades (4)
- Elegant (6)
- Popular action figure (2,3)
- Roam freely (6)
- Privy to (2,2)
- Simile centre (2,1)
- Very eager or expectant (3,4)
- Burn with hot liquid (5)
- Arabian spirits (5)
- Planetary path (5)
- Last stations (7)
- Acquit (5)
- Not ___ in the world : without any worries (1,4)

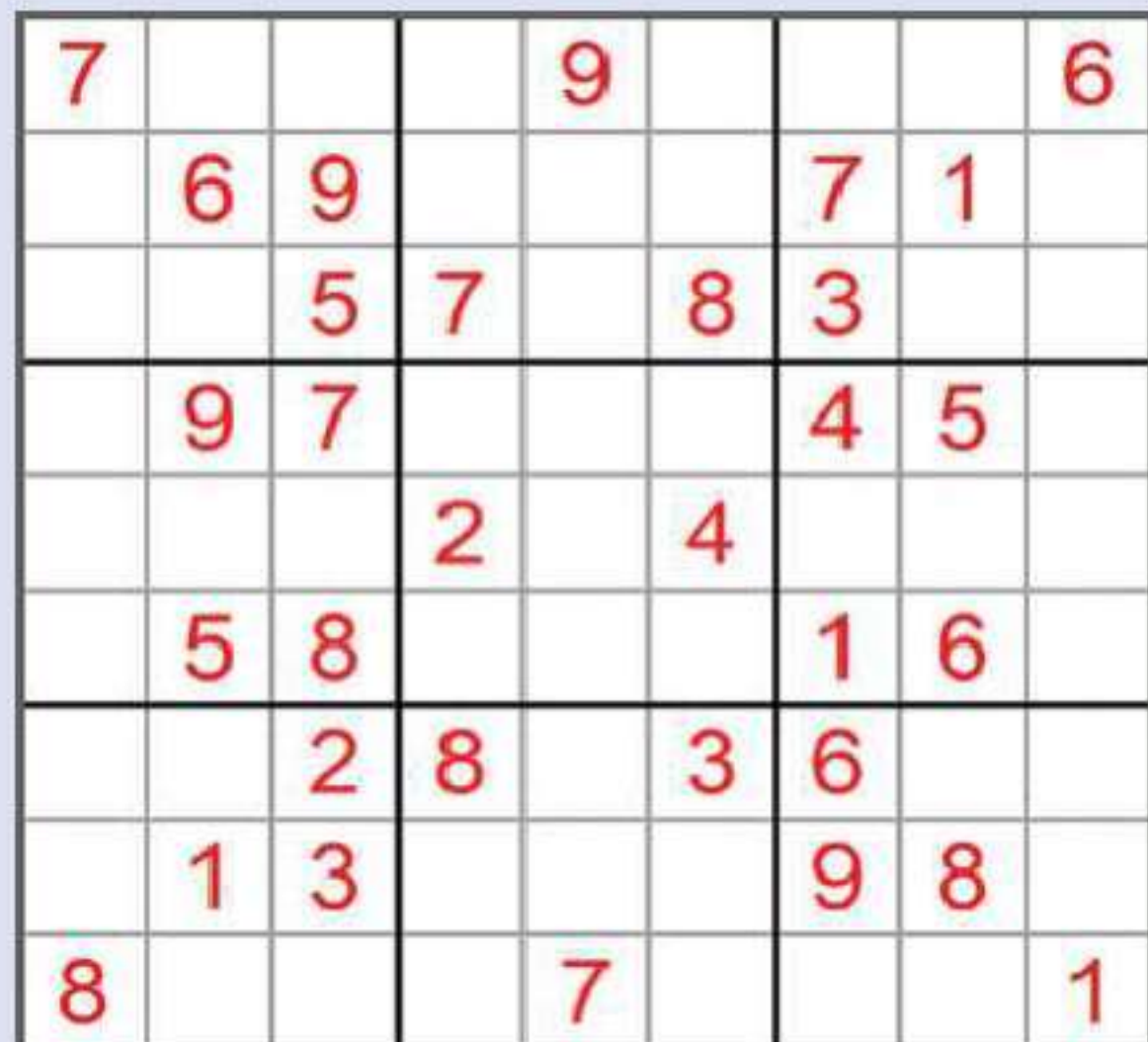
DOWN

- Frozen expanse (6)
- Intones (6)
- Family (3)
- Pierces (5)
- Novelist France of France (7)
- Result of hen's laying? (4)
- Picks or chooses (6)
- Man's pet name - "a rite" anagram? (5)
- Venomous snake (5)
- Fragrance (5)
- Utilizing (5)
- Watching (5)
- Was able (5)
- Moving ice layer (7)
- Too (2,4)
- Medical (6)
- More damp with moisture, in a way? (6)
- Crockett's last battle (5)
- First lady of "Ramayana" (4)
- ___ roll: having a long spell of success (2,1)



Solution to October 2

SUDOKU



Solution to October 2



Beyond the engineering degree: Preparing students for work

AROOP KUMAR

For many Indian families, securing an engineering admission represents the culmination of years of effort. Once a college and branch are chosen, there is often an assumption that the degree will naturally lead to employment. But an important question can sometimes be overlooked: What kind of work is the student preparing to do?

The limits of a degree in a changing labour market

Recent engineering admissions in Telangana illustrate the scale of demand for technology-oriented programmes. Of the 88,053 seats available in the 2026 admission cycle, 62,509 were in computer science and IT-related programmes, according to the

figures cited in the original analysis. Artificial Intelligence, Robotics and related programmes also attracted strong demand.

Choosing a technology-related programme can provide students with relevant academic foundations, but the degree itself does not determine the professional role they will eventually pursue.

A computer science graduate interested in cybersecurity, for example, may need different practical exposure from a student preparing for an analytics role. Another student may be interested in software development, product management, research or technology applications in sectors such as healthcare and finance.

The qualification provides a starting point. Developing professional capabilities requires students to explore these possibilities and gain experience through projects, internships, research, competitions or other forms of practical work.

From knowledge to demonstrated skills

Hiring trends can provide useful context, but broad categories such as "technology jobs" do not explain what individual employers expect from candidates.

The more useful question for students is often what they can demonstrate. A project, for instance, becomes more meaningful when a student can explain the problem being addressed, why a particular approach was selected, what difficulties arose and what could be improved.

This is particularly relevant as artificial

intelligence becomes part of everyday learning and professional work. AI tools can assist students with research, coding, analysis and project development. At the same time, students need to understand the tools they use and be able to verify their outputs.

A student who uses AI to develop a project should be able to explain what the tool contributed, how the information was checked and which decisions were made independently. The objective is not simply to produce an impressive result, but to understand the process behind it.

Professional skills begin before placement season

Some of the capabilities employers look for are not limited to technical knowledge. Listening carefully, organising information, communicating an idea clearly, collaborating with others and responding to feedback are skills that develop through regular practice.

Students can begin building these abilities through group projects, presentations, internships, student organisations and interactions with professionals.

Maintaining a record of projects and reflecting on what was learned can also help students understand their own strengths and areas for improvement.

Colleges can support this process by giving students exposure to different professional roles before their final year. Practitioner interactions, supervised projects, internships and career guidance can help students connect academic subjects with possible career paths.

Employers, too, can contribute by communicating entry-level expectations clearly and providing opportunities for students to understand workplace requirements.

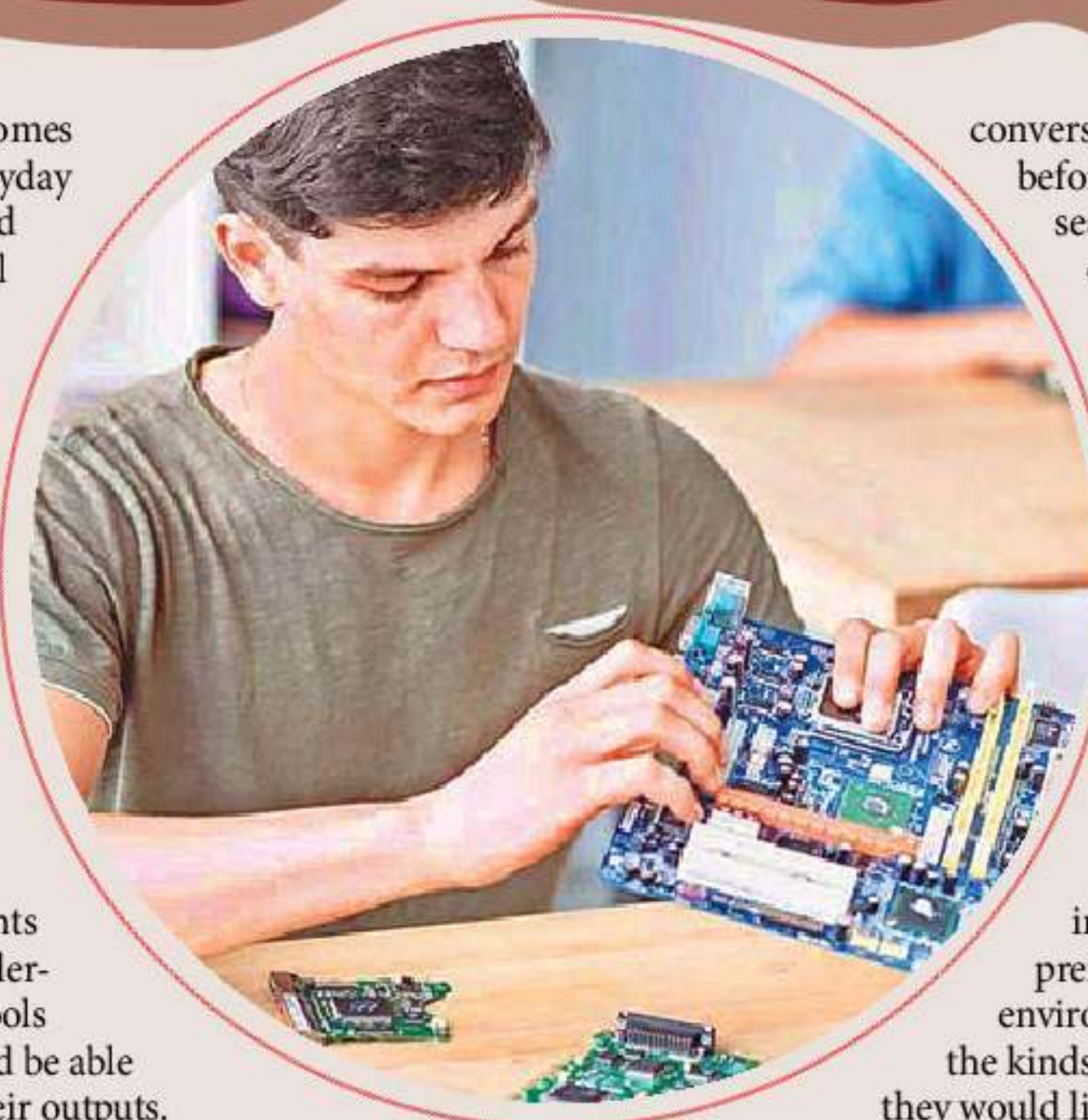
A broader conversation for parents and students

Parents can also play a role by beginning career

conversations well before placement season. Instead of focusing only on salary packages or the reputation of a particular role, discussions can include questions about the student's interests, preferred working environment and the kinds of problems they would like to solve.

Students should also be allowed to revise their plans as they gain experience. An interest discovered through a project or internship may lead to a different direction from the one initially chosen. Certificates can document participation in a course, but practical work can provide stronger evidence of how knowledge has been applied. Even regular, focused practice can make a difference when students have a clear objective and receive feedback. Engineering education does not end with completing a degree. The college years can also be a period for students to understand the workplace, test different interests and develop the ability to demonstrate what they know.

(The author is founder of Welica, a career preparation platform)



Student leads community initiative on access to government health schemes

Student Anahita Nair has founded Cross-Roads, a youth-led community initiative that works to improve awareness and access to existing government healthcare schemes among eligible communities.



Anahita Nair

Government programmes such as AarogyaSri, Ayushman Bharat and ESI are intended to help eligible individuals access healthcare while reducing financial barriers. However, lack of awareness, language barriers and difficulties navigating enrolment and digital systems can prevent some beneficiaries from using these services.

CrossRoads focuses on addressing these last-mile challenges through awareness sessions and practical assistance. The initiative conducts programmes in schools, workplaces, residential communities and villages, explaining aspects such as eligibility, coverage, enrolment procedures and access to empanelled hospitals. According to the initiative, its outreach programmes have so far reached more than 700 people. The sessions include bilingual question-and-answer interactions and individual guidance to help participants understand how government healthcare schemes may apply to their circumstances. As part of the effort to make information easier to understand, CrossRoads has also prepared and distributed more than 500 simplified Telugu-language guides. The guides provide information on scheme benefits, eligibility criteria, empanelled hospitals and enrolment procedures in a format intended for community use.

The initiative also provides offline and on-the-spot assistance to individuals who may face difficulties using digital platforms. This includes helping participants understand the steps involved in accessing or enrolling in available healthcare schemes.

Nair's initiative works with local communities and community leaders to address the gap between awareness of public welfare programmes and their use at the grassroots level. Rather than creating a separate healthcare support system, CrossRoads focuses on communicating information about existing government provisions and helping eligible individuals navigate the processes involved.

The initiative also highlights the role students and young people can play in community-based awareness efforts. By combining simplified information, local-language resources and direct guidance, the project addresses practical barriers that can affect access to public welfare services.

For students involved in such initiatives, the experience can also provide exposure to community engagement, communication and understanding how public programmes are implemented at the local level.

TODAY IS WORLD CARD MAKING DAY

Turning creativity into thoughtful greetings

Card making is a simple creative activity that gives students an opportunity to express their ideas while creating something personal for someone they care about.

Whether it is made during a holiday, a special occasion or simply as a thoughtful gesture, a handmade card can carry a message in a way that feels personal and meaningful.

Making a card does not require expensive materials. Students can use coloured paper, pencils, crayons, sketch pens, stickers, ribbons

or recycled materials to create their designs. They can experiment with shapes, patterns, drawings, cut-outs and handwritten messages to make each card unique.

The process also encourages creativity and patience. Students have to think about the person receiving the card, choose an appropriate design and decide what they want to say.

Writing a short personal message can also help students express appreciation, friendship, gratitude or good wishes. Card making can be an

enjoyable group activity as well. Friends can sit together, exchange ideas and help one another with designs. Schools can organise card-making sessions where students create cards for classmates, teachers, family members or community members.

The activity can also introduce students to the value of handmade creations in a digital age, when many greetings are shared through messages and social media.

Taking time to make something by hand can make the gesture more thoughtful.



UoH CONFERS 1,721 DEGREES AT 26TH CONVOCAATION

The University of Hyderabad (UoH) held its 26th Convocation at the Global Peace Auditorium, Brahma Kumaris Shanti Sarovar, Gachibowli, marking the graduation of students across various disciplines.

A total of 1,721 degrees, including 300 Ph.D. degrees, were conferred during the ceremony. The university also awarded 178 medals to students for academic performance and achievements.

The convocation was presided over by UoH Chancellor Justice L. Narasimha Reddy. Telangana Governor and Chief Rector Shri Shiv Pratap Shukla, Vice-Chancellor Professor J. Anuradha and Dr Samir V. Kamat, former Chairman of the Defence

Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) and chief guest, attended the event. Addressing the graduating students, Justice L. Narasimha Reddy congratulated them on their academic journey and encouraged them to remain curious, empathetic and responsible in their future pursuits. He emphasised the importance of using education responsibly and contributing to society while maintaining integrity and inclusivity.

Dr Samir V. Kamat urged graduates to remain adaptable and continue learning as they enter professional and academic environments. Drawing on his experience at DRDO, he spoke about the importance of taking calculated risks, developing new skills and

working collaboratively. He also referred to the long-standing association between DRDO and UoH through the DRDO Industry Academia Centre of Excellence.

Governor Shiv Pratap Shukla encouraged graduates to remain humble and grounded after completing their studies. He emphasised that education extends beyond academic qualifications and includes character, values and social responsibility.

Presenting the university's achievements for 2025-26, Vice-Chancellor Professor J. Anuradha highlighted its research, academic and international activities. The university reported 179 active research projects valued at more than Rs

184 crore, while 34 faculty members were recognised among the world's top two per cent of cited researchers.

The university also reported collaborations under the Rs 100-crore ANRF-PAIR initiative, involving six institutions and around 180 investigators, as well as initiatives supporting deep-tech startups through ASPIRE. Other developments included new interdisciplinary research facilities, international academic collaborations and a four-year undergraduate Chemistry programme under NEP 2020.

The university also announced the 2026 Chancellor's Awards for five faculty members for contributions across

research, teaching and student mentoring. The recipients were Dr T. Saravanan, Dr Jogi Madhuprakash, Dr Ramachandrarao Yalla, Dr Anagha Ingole and Dr Nareish Annem.

Among the medal recipients, Dilip Kumar received the Dr Nandivada Rathnasree Medal for Best Ph.D. Thesis in Astrophysics/Theoretical Physics, while Sreya P.K. received the Prof. N. Siva Kumar Medal for Best Ph.D. Thesis in Life Sciences. Amruta Vilas Barbadikar received the Raj Narhari Pershad Medal for the Best Ph.D. Thesis in Sanskrit Studies. Dorothy Diengdoh received the Sarojini Naidu Memorial Trust Medal, CT Indra Endowment Medal and SC/ST Medal.



I think it's also going to be a swan song for him (Rohit) and a couple of players. This Cricket World Cup (2027) could be their last swan song, players like Virat Kohli, Mitchell Starc, who have been unbelievable servants for One-Day International games. So that's the excitement, as this is a stage for those guys for the last time to show how good they are.

- Shaun Pollock, former South Africa cricket captain

Sports Nation

Boxers punch their way to triple-gold haul

► **Lovlina, Parveen end 12-year wait for India's women boxers, join legendary Mary Kom**

► **Ankush becomes India's first male boxer to win gold after Amit Panghal in 2018**

► **India races to Asiad top-5 with 'Golden Six' on penultimate day**

NISHIO (JAPAN)

INDIAN boxers delivered a sensational hat-trick of gold medals at the Asian Games with Lovlina Borgohain (75kg), Parveen Hooda (65kg) and Ankush Panghal (80kg) producing contrasting but stirring performances in their respective finals here on Friday.

Lovlina defeated China's Ziyi Bao 5-0 on her 29th birthday to upgrade the silver she had won at the last edition. Parveen then eked out a narrow 3-2 split-decision win

over Paris Olympic bronze-medallist Chen Nien-chin of Chinese Taipei to claim her maiden Asian Games gold. Ankush then became the first Indian male boxer since Amit Panghal in 2018 to win an Asian Games gold medal.

Lovlina and Parveen ended a 12-year wait by joining legendary MC Mary Kom in the select group of Indian women boxers to have won Asian Games gold. The Manipuri had claimed the flyweight (51kg) title at the 2014 Games in Incheon. India thus fin-

ished atop the boxing medals tally, signing off with six medals, including three golds, its best-ever performance at the Asian Games in terms of gold medals. Besides the gold, Priya Ghanghas (60kg), Kapil Pokhariya (90kg) and Narender Berwal (+90kg) won bronze medals.

The country's best overall haul came at the Guangzhou 2010 edition, where the contingent won nine medals -- two gold, three silver and four bronze.



Lovlina Borgohain, Parveen Hooda and Ankush Panghal

India face potential 'banana peel' in Pak on tricky track

NAGOYA: World champions India, boasting a formidable line-up of T20 stars, will look to underline their supremacy on the cricket field when they take on Pakistan in the men's gold-medal clash at the Asian Games on Saturday. Not an inch would be spared on 22 yards and off it, there is little or no chance of players shaking hands, having started the trend during Asia Cup last year, unlike their volleyball, TT or hockey counterparts who shook hands and hugged after end of their duels. The standard of competition in cricket is pretty poor at the Games but the stakes of a nation that believes in using sport as a soft power, the significance of a gold medal, that too by beating Pakistan, is immense. Not often does a team win a gold medal by winning merely two matches but the persistent rainfall led to both India and Pakistan entering the final with easy wins in their respective semi-finals. For interim head coach VVS Laxman and new T20 skipper Shreyas Iyer a final against a second rung Pakistan side led by Sahibzada Farhan is like a 'banana peel'. Battle between spinners of two sides The underlying moisture and bright sunshine has led to un-

even bounce and good amount of turn makes the role of Axar Patel, Washington Sundar, Ravi Bishnoi important along with the legendary Burmah, whose skill-set has always been surface independent. Even Abhishek Sharma will have a role to play if the turn on offer is more than significant. At the other end, Pakistan will depend on their two wrist spinners Abrar Ahmed and Sufiyan Moqim along with wrist spinners Saim and Arafat. The match will be won and lost in those 16 overs that spinners from either side will be bowling.

TEAMS

India: Shreyas Iyer (captain), Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, Abhishek Sharma, Sanju Samson (wk), Shreyas Iyer, Ishan Kishan, Tilak Varma, Shivam Dube, Jasprit Bumrah, Washington Sundar, Axar Patel, Ravi Bishnoi, Vipraj Nigam, Yash Thakur, Arshdeep Singh.

Pakistan: Sahibzada Farhan (captain), Saim Ayub, Maaz Sadaqat, Usman Khan, Hasan Nawaz, Abdul Samad, Arafat Minhas, Mohammed Wasim, Ahmed Daniyal, Sufiyan Moqim, Abrar Ahmed, Akif Javed, Ali Raza, Saad Masood, Haider Ali.



Loyola Academy wins OU inter-college fencing c'ship

HYDERABAD: Loyola Academy emerged overall winners of the OU Inter-College Fencing Championships held at R.G. Kedia College of Commerce on Thursday.

In Men's Sabre, A Harireshan Reddy of Vasavi topped the field, followed by K Vinayak Raj and Viraj. Ellyasuddin of Government City won Men's Foil, while Sanjay of Loyola Academy claimed the Epee title.

Loyola Academy won the team championship, with Vasavi Engineering College and Government City College sharing runner-up honours. Sr. Prof. Rajesh Kumar, Head, Department of Physical Education, OU, inaugurated the tournament.

Wrestler Sujeet's golden comeback

SUJEET Kalkal underlined his growing supremacy in the men's 65kg category by clinching the Asian Games gold here on Friday, defeating Olympic champion Kotaro Kiyooka en route to the title and erasing a massive 2-9 deficit in the final to add yet another crown to his tally in a stunning year of domination.

Stronger Iranian and Japanese rivals were expected to make life tough for Sujeet in a tricky draw but it was Tajikistan's Abdulmazhid Kudiev who tested the Indian most by racing to a 9-2 lead.

Using his tremendous speed and technical skills, Sujeet found a way to make a dramatic turnaround and prevail 10-9, scoring eight points in a row and holding off his rival.

Kudiev did not let Sujeet attack by employing arm locks in the first period. Once Sujeet got a measure of his rival's style he did not let him make any attacking move.

It is Sujeet's first Asian Games gold and the 23-year-old Indian has now swept the U23 World Championships, Asian Championships, Zagreb Open, Tirana title in the last 12 months, winning virtually everything that has come his way. His only setback came at the Mongolian Open in June, where a knee injury forced him to withdraw, but otherwise Sujeet has been unbeaten in his pursuit of the biggest titles on offer.

WOMEN'S RECURVE TEAM ENDS GOLD DROUGHT

THE women's recurve team's stunning win over 10-time Olympic champions South Korea for a historic gold headlined the highly productive day for Indian archery competition where the men's recurve and mixed recurve squads signed off with commendable silver medals.

The strong recurve performance comes after the compound archers completed a golden sweep in all the team competitions. India have so far secured seven medals, including four gold, two silver and a bronze, in the archery event here.

The first medal of the day for the Indian contingent came via the trio of Ankitat, Kirti and Kumkum, who



held their nerve in challenging windy conditions to outshoot the defending champions 5-3 (54-54, 56-56, 55-51, 54-54) and script a memorable triumph.

Kumkum then returned to the range with Dhiraj

Bommadevara and combined for a silver medal in the mixed recurve team event, with the Indian duo going down 3-5 (34-38, 35-37, 37-36, 37-37) to China in the final. After this, the men's recurve combination

of Bommadevara, Sanjay Bhoge and Neeraj Chauhan settled for a silver following a 1-5 loss (56-56, 50-57, 54-56) to Korea.

With the women's hockey team winning a long-awaited gold as well as Olympic qualification, India surged into the Asian Games top-five with a brilliant six-gold haul on the penultimate day of competitions here on Friday. India are now at the sole fifth position with 76 medals, including 16 gold, 25 silver and 35 bronze. The country has more medals than fourth-placed Uzbekistan (65) but lags in the gold count by four. But India seems to be heading for a strong finish if the Friday show is any indication.

4TH TIME LUCKY: SAILOR NETHRA KUMANAN CLAIMS BRONZE

INDIA'S Nethra Kumanan on Friday clinched the bronze medal in the women's dinghy event of the Asian Games sailing competition here, securing her first podium finish at the continental showpiece in her fourth appearance. The 29-year-old two-time Olympian from Chennai logged 14 points in all (7 in final and 7 from quali-



cation races) to be placed third behind gold-winner

Sophia Montgomery (5) of Thailand and silver-medal-

ist Jania Ang (13) of Singapore.

Bronze in sepaktakraw

The Indian team went down fighting 0-2 to hosts Japan in the men's quadrant semifinals to settle for a bronze medal in the Sepaktakraw competition of the Asian Games here on Friday. India lost the last-four match 12-15, 13-15.

TN officials suspended over Hindi in highway signboard

CHENNAI: Two officials were suspended for violating the official two-language policy of Tamil and English, and using Hindi words on a signboard on a State Highway, the Tamil Nadu government said in Chennai on Friday.

The Hindi words were erased from the signboard and departmental action has also been initiated against them, who are assistant engineers with the highways department, the government said.

On a newly installed sign-



board on Sattthankulam-Nazareth State Highway (SH-93) in Tuticorin District, in addition to Tamil and English, the names of towns were embossed in Hindi as well.

As soon as the government learnt about it, the Hindi words were erased, an official

release said.

The government said, "The two officials who were responsible for the inclusion of Hindi on the signboard by violating the two-language policy, have been suspended and departmental action has been initiated." -- PTI

'Abandoning' NEET leak fight by CJP

Latur students protest against CJP's Dipke

LATUR: A group of students held a protest in Latur on Friday against Cockroach Janta Party founder Abhijeet Dipke for "abandoning" the NEET exam paper leak fight and moving on to other issues. They sought answers from Dipke on the assurances the government had given after the CJP's agitation in Jantar Mantar, which resulted in the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as Union education minister on July 25.

The group assembled at Gandhi Chowk in Latur with placards and indulged in sloganeering against Dipke. Some of them also hit a poster of the CJP founder with slippers. "Why is Dipke now silent on the NEET issue? What has happened to the NEET case? What has Dipke done on the issue of compensation for NEET students who allegedly committed suicide after the NEET exam paper leaked? He should take up the matter with the Centre and fight for the future of students," the group's leader, Satish Karande, said. Speaking to PTI, Karande claimed the group had been in touch with Dipke for the last one-and-half months but the CJP chief and his associates were giving "evasive" answers. "Nothing concrete is



being done on the NEET issue. We had expected Dipke, who had emerged as a leader during the earlier NEET agitation, to continue fighting for the students. He took up the issue of ZP schools, left it midway and now has gone to Mumbai," Karande said. Karande said Dipke should have worked on the NEET issue to ensure question papers don't get leaked in the future. Dipke and his CJP are heading a protest in Shivaji Park in the metropolis seeking the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar over alleged irregularities in the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

MP Water contamination deaths

Cong leader compares Indore to African villages

INDORE

CONGRESS leader Umang Singhar on Friday slammed the ruling BJP in Madhya Pradesh following the judicial commission's report on the deaths caused due to contaminated water in Indore, saying the drinking water situation in this major city was like that of small African villages.

The Leader of Opposition in the state assembly also demanded filing of an FIR against those responsible for the deaths of several citizens due to contaminated drinking water supply in the Bhagirathpura area of the city, and also sought the resignation of Mayor Pushyamitra Bhargava.

Talking to reporters in Indore, Singhar said, "A major investigation report was prepared on the drinking water

Singhar demands FIR against culprits



tragedy, but the situation remains akin to the proverbial 'mountain dug only to find a mouse' because even after the report was released, the state government has not taken any action against those responsible."

He said Chief Minister

Mohan Yadav should immediately take necessary action and an FIR should be filed against those responsible. Singhar claimed that even as months have passed since the drinking water crisis hit Indore, the citizens and patients in government hospitals are forced to drink contaminated water.

The state government has failed to provide clean drinking water to people despite numerous assurances made in the assembly, according to him. "The Indore Municipal Corporation has an annual budget of Rs 8,500 crore. Despite this, the drinking water situation in a large city like Indore is like that of small villages in Africa," he said.

Singhar claimed that the ruling BJP in the state never wanted the investigation

report of the judicial commission formed into the Bhagirathpura contaminated drinking water case to be made public.

He alleged that the state government resorted to non-cooperation and manipulation before the one-member commission headed by former High Court judge Sushil Kumar Gupta to protect Cabinet Minister and local MLA Kailash Vijayvargiya, Mayor Pushyamitra Bhargava, and area councillor Kamal Baghel.

Singhar said that the commission was not provided with documents related to the drinking water and sewerage pipelines even when requested.

Citing the report, he said that a pipeline project in Bhagirathpura was delayed by a total of 859 days, from the tender call to completion.

Wakode's death: IIT Bombay students begin hunger strike

MUMBAI: A group of IIT Bombay students protesting the alleged suicide of second-year student Sahil Wakode on Friday started a hunger strike demanding accountability from the institute administration and the resignation of its director.

The students, who have been protesting for the past 15 days, decided to intensify their agitation after Wakode's parents, who are on hunger strike at Mumbai's Azad Maidan, were denied permission by police to continue their protest on weekends.

Sahil Wakode was found dead in his hostel room at the Indian Institute of Technology Bombay on September 18 after allegedly being caught cheating during a mid-semester exam.

The protesting students marched towards the main gate on Friday and presented an 18-point charter of demands to the administration.

'Were seconds from dying': Dentist on Flydubai attack

NEW DELHI

AN ordinary journey transformed into a desperate fight for survival when an Israeli dentist aboard a FlyDubai service sprang into action, combining quick thinking and medical expertise to save the severely injured captain after a mid-air cockpit attack.

Dr Shota Musaev recounted that upon rushing toward the flight deck alongside fellow passengers after Capt Smi Machchhar was assaulted, he instantly focused on how he

could intervene to protect everyone on board.

"I think, how [can] I help this situation for all [the passengers for all plane]. How I can help," he told ABC News. "And I see one pilot on the floor, with blood."

The flight, designated as FlyDubai Flight 1073 travelling from Dubai to Tel Aviv, plunged roughly 16,000 feet in just two minutes after the co-pilot allegedly stabbed Captain Machchhar with a knife in a suspected terrorist attempt to force the aircraft into a nose



dive.

Amid the chaos, passenger Yaniv Hayun dragged the assailant from the controls, levelled the aircraft, and allowed a third pilot to land safely in Tabuk, Saudi Arabia, ensuring all 180 passengers survived unharmed.

Recounting the immediate aftermath inside the cabin,

Dr Musaev explained how he and another passenger utilised headphones to bind the attacker's hands.

Once restrained, the suspect offered little explanation aside from stating he originated from Oman before repeatedly pleading, "Kill me, kill me, please."

"Once he had been subdued, caught, he didn't resist," Musaev noted. Shifting his focus to the flight deck, Dr Musaev administered emergency medical treatment to Captain Machchhar, applying

direct pressure to stem profuse bleeding from wounds sustained to the head, neck, and hands.

"Everything will be good," Musaev recalled telling the pilot. "He said to me, 'Help me, please. Help me, please. I don't want to die here.'"

Reflecting on the terrifying 40-minute ordeal after landing in Saudi Arabia, Dr Musaev shared the sheer scale of the near-tragedy with ABC News, choking up as he asked, "Do you understand we were five to 10 seconds from dying?"

Real estate capital inflows more than double to \$9.5 bn

Data centres, offices and development sites account for 91% of Q3 capital deployed

NEW DELHI

INDIA'S real estate sector attracted equity capital inflows of \$9.5 billion in the July-September quarter (Q3 2026), the highest quarterly figure on record, as inflows more than doubled on a year-over-year basis, a report said.

The upswing was primarily driven by rising investors' appetite for data centres and continued capital deployment into built-up office assets and land/development sites, said the report from CBRE South Asia.

The equity capital inflows in Q3 also more than doubled on a quarter-over-quarter basis from \$3.8 billion in Q2, 2026.

The total capital inflows in the first nine months of 2026 reached \$18.6 billion, nearly double the level recorded in the corresponding period of 2025 and already surpassing the full-year inflows of \$14.2 billion in 2025.

"Global investors have re-



turned with conviction, and institutional capital is now flowing well beyond offices and land into data centres. It reflects how deep and diverse India's real estate market has become, and we expect this confidence to carry through the rest of the year," said An-

shuman Magazine, Chairman and CEO, India, South-East Asia, Middle East and Africa, CBRE.

Sustained capital deployment into built-up asset acquisitions and new project developments across traditional and emerging real

estate sectors further supports this outlook, the report noted.

Mumbai, Delhi-NCR and Chennai accounted for a cumulative share of about 53 per cent of investment inflows during the quarter.

Data centres, built-up of-

fice assets and land or development sites together accounted for nearly 91 per cent of total capital deployed in Q3 2026. Investment in data centres grew multi-fold over both the previous quarter and the same period last year, reflecting strong investor confidence in the asset class, the report noted.

Foreign investors made a significant comeback during the quarter, accounting for about 59 per cent of total inflows. The US investors contributed 90 per cent of foreign capital in Q3 2026, followed by investors from Canada, Singapore and Japan.

The return of global capital was accompanied by wider participation from institutional investors, particularly towards data centres and built-up office assets. Institutional investors accounted for nearly 79 per cent of overall inflows in Q3 2026, up from about 28 per cent in the previous quarter.

Festive season may give housing demand another boost

Hyderabad, Bengaluru lead recovery in India's housing market

NEW DELHI

HOUSING sales in India's seven major cities rose 3 per cent annually to over 1 lakh units during July-September on better demand in Mumbai Metropolitan Region, Bengaluru and Hyderabad, according to Anarock.In value terms, Anarock said that the total sales rose by 2 per cent to Rs 1.55 lakh crore during July-September from Rs 1.52 lakh crore in the corresponding period of the preceding year.Last week, real estate data analytics firm PropEquity pointed out that the total sales fell 6 per cent to 1.03 lakh units during the September quarter.

On Monday, real estate consultant Anarock released its data for the primary housing market for the July-September quarter, stating that the average residential property price across the top seven cities collectively witnessed annual growth of 7 per cent. Sales of residential properties stood at 1,00,220 units during July-September this year, up from 97,080 in the year-ago period.Sales rose in



Mumbai Metropolitan Region (MMR), Bengaluru and Hyderabad but declined in Delhi-NCR, Pune, Chennai and Kolkata.

Anarock Chairman Anuj Puri highlighted that MMR and Bengaluru accounted for 48 per cent of the total sales across the top seven cities in Q3 2026.As per the data, housing sales in Mumbai Metropolitan Region (MMR) rose 5 per cent to 31,750 units in July-September 2026 from 30,260 units in the year-ago period. In Bengaluru, the sales increased 12 per cent to 16,670 units from 14,835 units.Sales of residential properties in Hyderabad rose 15 per cent to 12,970 units from 11,305

units.However, in Pune, sales declined 6 per cent to 15,690 units from 16,620 units.In Delhi-NCR, sales dipped 1 per cent to 13,765 units from 13,920 units.Chennai saw a 10 per cent fall in sales to 5,395 units from 6,010 units. Sales in Kolkata decreased 4 per cent to 3,980 units in the July-September quarter from 4,130 units in the year-ago period.The top seven cities saw approx. 1,14,320 units launched in Q3 2026, against 96,690 units in Q3 2025 -- an 18 per cent annual increase."The upcoming festive season is expected to boost residential demand, building on the momentum seen in the September quarter," Puri of Anarock said.

Hyderabad, NCR set to drive mall expansion

NEW DELHI: Indian real estate developers are expected to add nearly 51.1 million sq. ft. of new shopping mall space over the next five years, propelling the total shopping mall stock to 143.2 million sq. ft. by the end of 2031, a report said on Monday.

The report from JLL said that the significant expansion is driven by surging

consumer demand, a strong influx of international brands and expansion by domestic brands.

India recorded gross leasing volumes of 6.3 million sq. ft in the first half of 2026. India's retail stock reached 92.1 million sq. ft. across the top 7 cities with a vacancy rate of 11.2 per cent as of June 2026. Of the total upcoming mall sup-

ply, nearly 56 per cent will comprise large-format malls designed to cater to the experiential and destination needs of shoppers. Over half of the upcoming retail supply is expected in Delhi NCR and Hyderabad. "The shift toward large-format, experiential destinations signals a fundamental transformation in how consumers engage and how consump-

tion patterns are evolving with changing generational preferences," said Saket Amrit, Head of Retail Services, India, JLL. Nearly one-third of upcoming supply is dedicated to entertainment, F&B, and services, signalling expansion beyond traditional commerce to create lifestyle destinations that blend technology, design, and experience.

Hyd follows B'luru in office space demand

NEW DELHI: Office space leasing across India's top seven markets rose 7 per cent year-on-year to 54.4 million square feet in the first nine months of 2026 because of sustained occupier expansion, demand from global capability centres and growing uptake by flexible workspace operators, a report showed.

According to a report by property consultant Colliers, Grade A office demand in the

third quarter reached 18.7 million sq ft, a record high for a third quarter in recent years and 7 per cent higher than the previous quarter.

The demand was also up 9 per cent from a year earlier, it added.

City-wise, Bengaluru led leasing activity during January-September with 15.7 million sq ft, accounting for 29 per cent of total demand, while Hyderabad followed

with 9.4 million sq ft, up 47 per cent year-on-year.

Meanwhile, Delhi-NCR recorded 8.3 million sq ft of leasing during the period. Mumbai, Pune and Chennai saw demand of 7.1 million sq ft, 6.9 million sq ft and 6 million sq ft, respectively.

Moreover, five of the seven markets recorded annual growth in leasing during the nine-month period, according to the report.

The report further noted that annual office transactions across the major markets could reach 75-80 million sq ft in 2026.

"With cumulative Grade A space uptake already at 54.4 million sq ft, and demand prospects looking strong in the final quarter, we are well poised for a stronger 2026," said Arpit Mehrotra, managing director, office services, Colliers India.

BIZ BRIEFS

Indo-UK meet held

Asia Today Media organised the Indo-UK Leadership Conclave 2026 at the House of Lords, UK Parliament, London, bringing together British public representatives and professionals, doctors, educationists and entrepreneurs from India. The conclave focused on strengthening India-UK cooperation in trade, investment, education, healthcare, entrepreneurship and professional exchange.

Amazon sale from Oct 8

Amazon's Great Indian Festival 2026 will begin on October 8, offering discounts across smartphones, electronics, fashion, beauty, home, kitchen and everyday essentials. Customers can get 10% instant discounts on SBI cards, while Amazon Pay ICICI Bank cardholders receive cashback benefits. Saurabh Srivastava, VP, Amazon India, said: "This Amazon Great Indian Festival, lakhs of sellers and leading brands including Samsung, Apple, Sony, LG, Xiaomi, Nike and L'Oréal Paris are bringing customers the lowest prices of the year on lakhs of products."

Ultraviolette expands presence

Ultraviolette Automotive has expanded its presence in Andhra Pradesh with opening of a UV Space Station in Anantapur. Narayan Subramaniam, CEO, Ultraviolette, said: "Anantapur is an important market for us as we continue to deepen our presence across Andhra Pradesh and build a stronger footprint across the region. The city's evolving industrial ecosystem, expanding mobility needs and growing adoption of electric mobility make it an important market."

Anant Ambani announces ₹1L cr Reliance bet on AP

Reliance investment to support cleaner energy and new opportunities for farmers

HANS BUSINESS
MADANAPALLE

RELIANCE Industries plans to invest Rs 1 lakh crore in Andhra Pradesh to set up compressed biogas (CBG) plants, creating over 3 lakh jobs and generating nearly Rs 60,000 crore in revenue for the State over the coming decades, Reliance Industries Executive Director Anant M Ambani said on Friday.

Speaking at the foundation stone laying ceremony for the Rayalaseema Horticulture Hub and Indian School of Agriculture (ISA) in Madanapalle, Ambani said the investment would support the State's transition towards cleaner energy while creating new opportunities for farmers.

"Our kisans, who ensure India's food security, will now strengthen India's energy security too - making India self-reliant in energy," he said. "That is why Reliance Industries is grateful to the Government of Andhra Pradesh for the opportunity to invest Rs 1 lakh crore in the state to set up compressed biogas (CBG) plants."

CBG is produced by processing agricultural residue, animal dung, food waste and other biomass into methane-rich gas, providing a cleaner alternative to conventional natural gas. Ambani said the plants would create over 3 lakh jobs and bring nearly Rs 60,000 crore in revenue to the State over the next decades.

He said Reliance was also investing in clean-energy projects in Rayalaseema and exploring opportunities in advanced manufacturing. Citing State government



Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, AP Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu, industrialist Anant Ambani and IT and Electronics Minister Nara Lokesh at the foundation stone laying ceremony for Global Horticulture Hub project and Indian School of Agriculture at Madanapalle on Friday

data, Ambani said Andhra Pradesh had approved 388 mega projects since June 2024, with investment commitments exceeding Rs 14 lakh crore and potential employment of nearly 11 lakh people. About a third of these investments are headed to Rayalaseema, he said.

On the ISA, Ambani said Reliance would support it through strategic investment, digital capabilities, technical expertise and industry partnerships. "I request you: Treat me as a son of Andhra," he told Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu.

The proposed Rs 40,000-crore horticulture hub will promote technology-driven agriculture in Rayalaseema. "Today, the Rayalaseema Horticulture Hub, backed by Rs 40,000 crore, brings the rising sun of India's growth to Rayalaseema," Ambani said.

He said the ISA would combine artificial intelli-

₹1 LAKH CRORE PLAN TO TURN RAYALASEEMA INTO FRUIT BOWL

MADANAPALLE
(ANNAMAYYA DIST)

ANDHRA Pradesh Government on Friday launched an ambitious project to transform the drought-prone Rayalaseema region into a Global Horticulture Hub and India's fruit bowl, with a comprehensive action plan involving an investment of

₹1 lakh crore. The project, along with the Indian School of Agriculture (ISA), was jointly launched at a public meeting here by Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu and Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman. Deputy Chief Minister Pawan Kalyan, IT and Electronics Minister Nara Lokesh, Agriculture Minister K. Atchannaidu and others were present.

lions of farmers in Indian languages through virtual classrooms in villages. Rural youth could also be trained as digitally enabled extension workers.

"Today, we are not just laying foundation stones. We are laying the foundations for rural enterprise, stronger villages, a more sustainable India, and most importantly, for improving the lives of our farmers," he said.

Domestic investors absorb FII selling pressure

MUMBAI

AFTER two consecutive months of buying, foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) turned net sellers in September, pulling out Rs 35,860 crore from Indian equities amid global uncertainties, elevated US interest rates and high crude oil prices.

The selling continued into October, with foreign investors pulling out another Rs 9,232 crore from equities on October 1, according to data from Central Depository Services Limited (CDSL). The outflows came after FPIs invested Rs 20,200 crore in Indian equities in July and Rs 29,630 crore in August. With the latest selling, FPIs have now withdrawn around Rs 2.7 lakh crore from Indian equities so far in 2026,

significantly higher than the Rs 1.66 lakh crore outflow recorded during the entire 2025. Rajesh Singla, Fund Manager & CEO at Alpha AMC, said FPIs were withdrawing from Indian equities largely due to external factors such as elevated crude prices amid Hormuz-related supply risks, a weak rupee, firm US bond yields, profit-taking following the July-August inflows and rotation towards AI-led North Asian markets. "This is a global allocation story, not a domestic earnings one," he said. Singla said domestic SIP flows were helping absorb the impact of foreign selling, while SME and small-cap segments, which have relatively limited FPI ownership, remained comparatively insulated. "Strategically, India's growth

case is intact; capital is rotating, not exiting," he added. Going ahead, analysts said FPI flows would be influenced by the ongoing Iran-US conflict and its impact on crude oil prices. Elevated crude prices and higher US bond yields, with the US 10-year yield at around 5 per cent, could weigh on Indian equities and FPI flows. However, the resilient Indian economy and expectations of stronger earnings growth remain positive factors, they said. Foreign investors also extended their selling to the debt market during September. They withdrew Rs 10,431 crore through the Fully Accessible Route (FAR), Rs 5,049 crore via the Voluntary Retention Route (VRR) and Rs 5,246 crore through the general route.

Telangana emerges as India's most data centre-friendly state

NEW DELHI

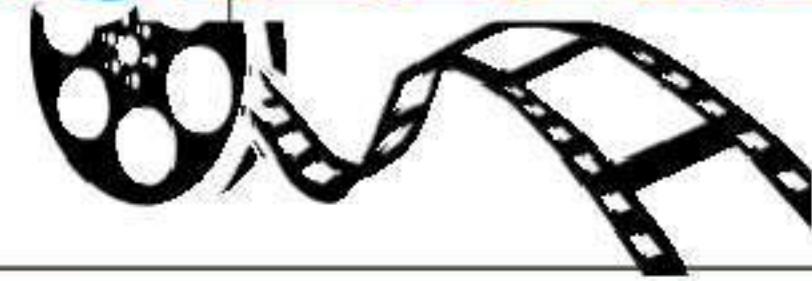
TELANGANA has emerged as the state offering the most attractive policy package for data centres in India, backed by strong electricity and regulatory incentives, while Maharashtra and Uttar Pradesh have formulated balanced frameworks with extensive packages covering power, infrastructure, capital, and regulatory mechanisms, according to a report by S&P Global. Gujarat has established the most lucrative electricity and ease of doing business measures focused on drawing hyperscalers, placing all four lead-

ing states at scores of around 50 out of 100 on S&P Global Energy's Data Center Policy Attractiveness India (DCPAI) index, the report, titled 'India Forward: Reimagining Growth', stated. The index evaluated 19 state policies -- spanning Information Technology (IT), IT-enabled services (ITeS), data centres, and Global Capability Centres (GCCs) -- across 11 states enacted since 2016. The rankings were assessed on four core incentive categories: electricity, land and capital, operational and technical support, and regulatory and Ease of Doing Business (EoDB) frameworks.

Star Health steps up cashless healthcare push in Rajahmundry

HANS BUSINESS
HYDERABAD

STAR Health and Allied Insurance Company brought together more than 100 hospital leaders representing about 75 healthcare providers in Rajahmundry as part of efforts to strengthen hospital partnerships and improve access to cashless healthcare. Srinivas KBB, Business Head, Star Health Insurance, said: Our focus is to deepen our presence across markets such as Rajahmundry, strengthen cashless access and work closely with healthcare partners to make the hospitalisation and claims journey simpler for customers. Stronger collaboration across the ecosystem will be critical to supporting the next phase of health insurance growth."



TELUGU CINEMA MID-NIGHT PREMIERES

Is social media negativity becoming a bigger threat?

SUHAS SISTU

THE reaction to The Paradise on its premiere proves that the movie-watching experience has transformed drastically in the social media age. The response was so overwhelming that even Nani expressed surprise out in the open. But this is not the first time that such a scenario has taken place. Similar occurrences have been witnessed for multiple big-ticket films, and it is only a matter of time before such a trend begins to dictate the reception of movies in the future.

There was a period of time when a star's film had a certain amount of breathing room after its launch. A Chiranjeevi or Balakrishna movie may have had rival fan groups, but they were still willing to wait for the time being. The overall public reaction, however, is no longer being delayed.

Once a film premieres, people can begin their discussions on X, Instagram and YouTube. Negativity does, however, tend to travel much faster



than positivity, so reactions that criticize a film tend to spread like wildfire shortly after the premiere.

Social media negativity has also affected some YouTube reviewers' ability to present balanced reactions to fresh releases.

The number of views one could expect from a review praising a film would be vastly lower than if one were to criticize it. As the result, the first couple of hours of a film's release are now dominated by people looking for problems rather than enjoying the

film. As a consequence, film crews are now having a significantly more challenging experience. The first weekend, instead of focusing on the audience's reaction and the film's box-office success, the production team must deal with constant online negativity.

At the same time, however, it is unfair to blame the entire fault on social media. If a film has terrible content, then no matter how much money is spent promoting it on social media, the audience will not like it.

One additional factor worth

considering is the combination of premieres and price hikes. Some of the recently launched movies, including Peddi, Toxic, and The Paradise, have been embroiled in a controversy over expensive ticket prices and VIP premieres. If a film's cost is significantly higher than expected, audience members' expectations may also be affected. A minor weakness that would have gone unnoticed previously may be criticized.

It is not necessary for filmmakers to give up premieres and price hiking completely. However, it is crucial for producers to understand that such decisions frequently provoke more criticism than praise in the current Telugu cinema landscape.

After all, one thing is apparent, content is the best defense against social media negativity. The overall reaction to the film will always be dependent on the audience's experience with the content. The filmmaker's primary goal should be for the product to be able to withstand the scrutiny that comes with the territory almost immediately after the launch.



'Ranabaali' documentary series latest episode throws light on contribution of Rayalaseema warriors

THE third episode of the documentary series Ranabaali – Never Forget The Truth, called 'The Men We Forgot,' has been uploaded on YouTube. The episode reveals the historical background which inspired the character of Ranabaali in the upcoming pan-India film.

In the latest episode of the documentary, Rahul Sankrityan speaks about the legendary warriors of Rayalaseema who inspired him to create the character of

Ranabaali. He spoke about the valor and contribution of Budda Vengal Reddy, Uyyalawada Narasimha Reddy and Gadekal Bobbili Nagireddy.

"As a director, I feel extremely proud to showcase the legendary warriors of Rayalaseema. These warriors depicted the spirit of bravery and sacrifice. Budda Vengal Reddy was known to have helped thousands of people survive a severe famine. Uyyalawada Narasimha Reddy is

considered a great freedom fighter who bravely fought against the British," said Sankrityan, who is originally from Rayalaseema. The fourth episode, titled 'The Last Load,' will be out soon. Ranabaali, directed by Rahul Sankrityan and featuring Vijay Deverakonda and Rashmika in the lead roles, presented by T-Series and produced by Mythri Movie Makers. The film is set to release worldwide on October 16 on the occasion of Vijayadashami.

Shiva Kandukuri's 'Talkum Powder' locks Nov 13 release

National Award winner producer Raj Kandukuri, who has been supporting content driven films like Pelli Choopulu, Mental Madilo and C/O Kancharapalem is returning with yet another intriguing project Talkum Powder, which stars Shiva Kandukuri and Drishika Chander in the lead roles, written and directed by Sai Nath Ponna.

The makers have unveiled The First Sprinkle, a first look which introduces the audience to the film's quirky world and protagonist, Kuntya, a drug peddler who finds himself in an unbelievable situation due to an inadvertent mistake.

As the police and gangsters start hunting him down, the glimpse leaves the audiences speculating on the mistake that led Kuntya to this situation and the ways he plans to get out of it. With elements of crime-comedy and drama, the film promises to keep the audiences on tenterhooks with its unpredictable twists and quirky characters.

While Shiva Kandukuri's energetic screen presence shines through the



glimpse, the audience is also introduced to the other prominent characters like Venkatesh Maha, Jeevan Kumar, among others.

On the technical front, cinematography is handled by G.V. Ajay Kumar, while Osho V has composed the music and Surya Ponnappalli has edited the film.

Produced by Raj Kandukuri under Dharma Patha Creations, Talkum Powder is slated to release on 13th November.

AADHI PINISETTY'S 'Marakathamani 2' wraps filming

THE much-awaited Marakathamani 2, starring Aadhi Pinisetty has wrapped up shooting. The makers are rushing into the post-production work of the film now. The sequel bagged the attention of fans of the original film Marakathamani, released in 2017 and became a blockbuster hit in Telugu and Tamil.

Director ARK Saravanan, who directed the first part, is again holding the megaphone for the sequel. Apart from Aadhi Pinisetty, the film stars Sathyaraj, Priya Bhavani Shankar, Nikki Galrani Pinisetty, Munishkanth, Anandraj, Dani, Arunraja Kamaraj and Mruganandham.

Sudhan Sundaram, Manish Singhal, Durgaram Choudhary, Dev and KV Durai are producing it under the Passion Studios, Dangal TV, RDC Media, Access Film Factory and Good Show banners.



Dhibu Ninan Thomas is composing the music while cinematography is handled by P.V. Shankar and Deepak Menon, with N.K. Rahul overseeing the art direction and Thirumalai Rajan R handling the editing.

The makers are expected to reveal more information about Marakathamani 2 trailer, audio and worldwide theatrical release soon.

Neem Karoli Baba biopic 'Hanuman Ansh' to be released in Telugu on Oct 9

AFTER seeing off a successful run in Hindi, Hanuman Ansh will hit the Telugu screens on October 9. Inspired by spiritual guru Neem Karoli Baba, also referred to as Maharaj-ji, the biopic is ready to see South India audiences through the lens of Hombale Films.

Directed and written by Dr. Vishal Chaturvedi, the spiritual drama features Shobinaw Satyaa as the title character, with Chandan Anand and Purnima Tiwari playing pivotal parts. Hanuman Ansh recounts the life and teachings of Neem Karoli Baba, and offers a poignant



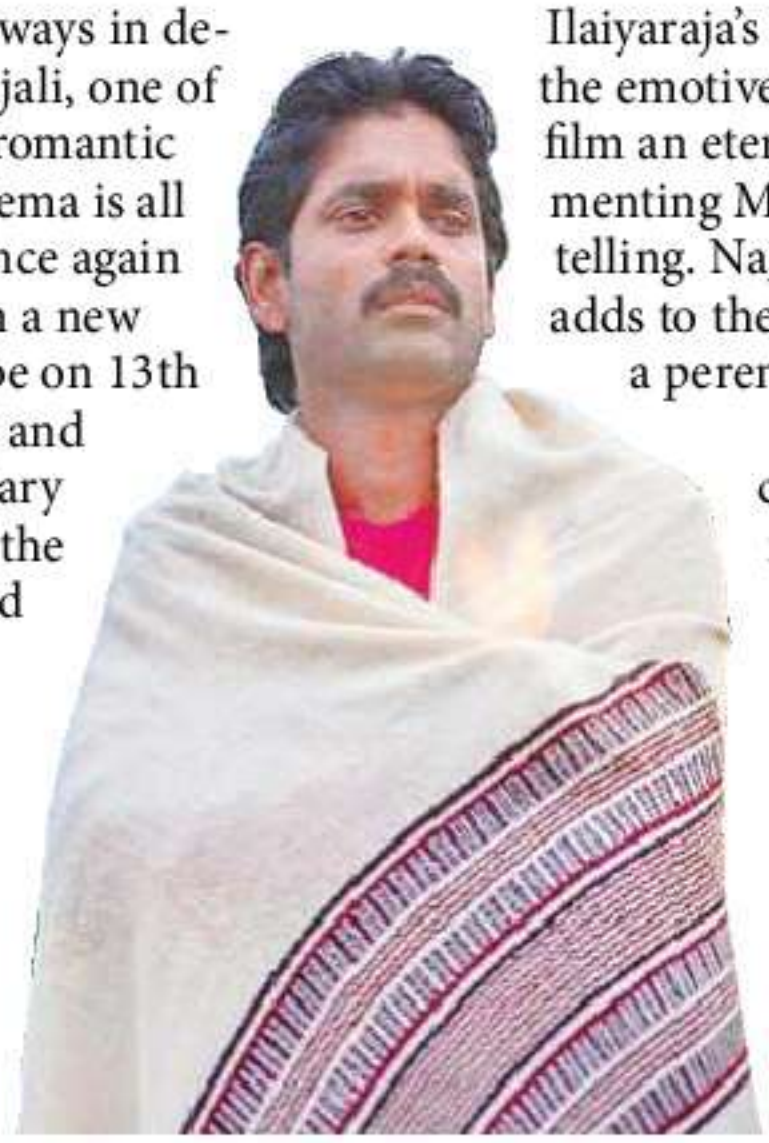
look into the world of faith and devotion. The film was apparently a surprise discovery in Hindi, garnering a strong response from moviegoers who connected to it on a personal level.

Hombale Films, which distributed the film overseas, has acquired the theatrical rights in South Indian languages. Hanuman Ansh will hence be seen in Telugu followed by a wide release in Tamil, Kannada and Malayalam. Shreyas Dharmadhikari has composed the music for the film while Rishi Pathak has been credited as music director.

Having wrapped up its Hindi theatrical run, Hanuman Ansh is all set to experience Telugu audiences and connect to a wider demographic interested in the story of Neem Karoli Baba.

Nagarjuna's classic 'Geethanjali' 4K set for Nov 13 re-release

CLASSIC movies are always in demand and Geethanjali, one of the most adorable romantic drama films in Telugu cinema is all set to allure the viewers once again in the theatres this time in a new 4K version across the globe on 13th November in both Telugu and Tamil. Directed by legendary filmmaker Mani Ratnam, the movie Geethanjali featured the enchanting pair of Nagarjuna and Girija and was a treat for the audience with its distinct style, soulful music, and a poignant narrative that continues to captivate hearts even decades after its release.



Ilaiyaraaja's soul-stirring melodies and the emotive background score lend the film an eternal charm, perfectly complementing Mani Ratnam's masterful storytelling. Nagarjuna's charismatic display adds to the appeal, making Geethanjali a perennial favorite.

Decades after its theatrical run, Geethanjali still fascinates the viewers with its unique association with romance, drama, and deep emotion.

Shree Padmini Cinemas CEO Boorle Shiva Prasad is all set to bring back the classic movie on the silver screen for the first time in 35 years, entertaining movie lovers in its new 4K version.

GAYATRI BHARDWAJ DAZZLES IN NEW PHOTOSHOOT

ACTRESS Gayatri Bhardwaj, who was seen in movies like Tiger Nag-Deswara Rao and Buddy, recently released new pictures from a photoshoot, which has her spotted in a confident and attractive avatar. The star appeared in a beautiful black at-

tire, highlighting her stunning curves for the camera. Gayatri wore a bodycon black dress with spaghetti straps and ruched detailing. She paired the elegant attire with long caramel-brown wavy hair cascading over one shoulder. Dewy makeup, shimmering eyes, and glossy nude lips completed her stunning look.

The actress kept her jewelry minimal but noticed the bold rings that went well with the set of pictures. Gayatri sat on a grey sofa with one hand behind her head and posed for the camera with a confident pose. Her pictures caught millions' attention on social media.

Apart from her mesmerizing looks, Gayatri has been preparing for her much-awaited project, a Telugu slasher action thriller #CULT, starring Vishwak Sen. The film is set to release on 30th October 2026. The movie has been considered one of Gayatri's most anticipated projects, and the actress' brilliant performance has been expected to elevate her career graph.



'Kotha Bangaru Lokam' pair reunites for Aha's 'Naa Wife Missing'

VARUN Sandesh and Shweta Basu Prasad reunite with the upcoming aha original Naa Wife Missing. The gripping series is all set to stream on the OTT platform and will be available in both Telugu and Tamil for the viewers.

Aha released an update regarding the series recently, creating more hype among the viewers about the mysterious story of Naa Wife Missing. With the caption 'Every case has a story. What is the truth in this case?', the aha team shared the latest information about the series.

In the earlier post, aha had given a sneak peek

into the story where Varun Sandesh's character reaches the police station to register a complaint regarding his wife's disappearance. However, the latest post has increased the curiosity of the viewers about what led to the wife's disappearance and the truth that the husband and the police will uncover. Naa Wife Missing will be the reunion of Varun Sandesh and Shweta Basu Prasad after years. The two had starred together in the hit romance Kotha Bangaru Lokam and gained immense popularity among the Telugu audiences. The duo's pairing is quite in demand these days, and

their much-awaited project has made the viewers curious.

